

MARCUS AURELIUS

MEDITATIONS



A NEW TRANSLATION



LECTIO EDITION 2026

MEDITATIONS



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Marcus Aurelius

170–180 CE

THE LECTIO EDITION

*Plain modern English — the sense of the original,
made to read with ease today.*

LECTIO

San Diego Institute of Technology

Meditations — the Lectio Edition.

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INTRODUCTION

Marcus Aurelius never meant these notes to be read. He was the most powerful man in the world — emperor of Rome — yet he wrote them at night, on campaign, as private reminders to himself about how to live: with reason, justice, and steadiness in the face of death. That is why the book has no argument and no audience. It is a mind talking to itself.

This Lectio Edition renders his Greek into clear, contemporary English — grounded in the public-domain translations of George Long (1862) and Méric Casaubon (1634) and checked against the original. Read it straight through, or tap any line to compare a historical translation or the Greek.

A Roman emperor's private notebook — Stoic reminders to himself on duty, mortality, and the mastery of one's own mind.

*“Such as are thy habitual thoughts, such
also will be the character of thy mind; for
the soul is dyed by the thoughts.”*

Marcus Aurelius, Meditations 5.16, tr. George Long (1862) — public
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BOOK

I

What I Learned, and From Whom

Marcus opens not with doctrine but with gratitude, naming the family, teachers, and friends who shaped him and the specific virtue he owes to each. It reads as a quiet inventory of a good character and where it came from.

- 1 From my grandfather Verus, I learned to be good-natured and to keep my temper under control.
- 2 From everything I heard and remembered about my father, I learned modesty and a strong, manly character.
- 3 From my mother, I learned reverence and generosity; to hold back not only from doing wrong but even from thinking it; and to live simply, far from the habits of the rich.
- 4 From my great-grandfather, I learned the value of not relying on public schools but having good teachers at home — and that this is something worth spending freely on.
- 5 From my tutor, I learned not to take sides among the racing teams at the Circus or the rival gladiators in the arena; to endure hard work, to want little, to do things with

my own hands, to mind my own business, and to refuse to listen to gossip.

6 From Diognetus, I learned not to waste myself on trivial things; not to believe the claims of magicians and quacks about spells and exorcisms; and not to take up fashionable hobbies like breeding fighting quails. He taught me to put up with plain speaking and to take philosophy seriously; he led me to hear the philosophers Bacchius, Tandasis, and Marcianus, to write dialogues as a boy, and to choose the simple camp-bed and animal skins of the Greek discipline.

7 From Rusticus, I came to see that my character needed work and discipline. He kept me from chasing clever showmanship, from writing on abstract theories, from delivering little sermons, and from showing off as a model of self-discipline or charity. He taught me to give up ornate rhetoric, poetry, and fine writing; to write plainly, like the simple letter he sent my mother from Sinuessia; to make peace readily with anyone who had wronged me, the moment they were willing; to read closely rather than settle for a superficial grasp; and not to nod along with people who only talk a lot. It was Rusticus who introduced me to Epictetus' teachings, lending me his own copy.

8 From Apollonius, I learned independence of mind and steady purpose — relying on reason and nothing else, even for a moment — and to stay the same person in sharp pain, in the loss of a child, and in long illness. In him I saw a living example of a man who could be both utterly firm and gentle, never irritable in teaching, who treated his real gift — his skill in explaining philosophy — as the least of his merits. From him I also learned how to accept favors from

friends without feeling diminished or letting them pass unacknowledged.

9 From Sextus, I learned kindness, and the example of a household run the way a good father runs his family; the idea of living in agreement with nature; dignity without pretense; and genuine care for my friends. He bore patiently with ignorant people and with those who hold opinions without thinking them through. He could get along with anyone — his company was more pleasant than any flattery, and yet people held him in the deepest respect. He had a gift for working out and arranging, clearly and methodically, the principles a life needs. He never showed anger or any other passion; he was at once completely calm and deeply affectionate. He gave praise quietly and carried great learning without ever parading it.

10 From Alexander the grammarian, I learned not to pounce on mistakes — not to embarrass someone for a slip in grammar or pronunciation, but to work the correct form smoothly into my reply, or by confirming the point, or by some other tactful prompt.

11 From Fronto, I learned how much envy, cunning, and hypocrisy come with absolute power, and that the people we call aristocrats tend to be rather short on ordinary human warmth.

12 From Alexander the Platonist, I learned not to say or write to people, often or without real need, that I am ‘too busy,’ and not to keep dodging my obligations to those around me by always pleading urgent business.

13 From Catulus, I learned not to brush off a friend’s complaint, even an unfair one, but to try to set things right; to

speak warmly of my teachers, as people say Domitius and Athenodotus did; and to love my children truly.

14 From my brother Severus, I learned to love my family, the truth, and justice. Through him I came to know Thræsea, Helvidius, Cato, Dion, and Brutus; and from him I got the idea of a society governed by one law for all, administered with equal rights and freedom of speech, and of a kingship that values above all the liberty of those it governs. He taught me a steady, undistracted devotion to philosophy; a readiness to do good and to give generously; optimism; and trust that my friends loved me. He never hid what he thought of those he disapproved of, so his friends never had to guess his wishes — it was simply plain.

15 From Maximus, I learned self-mastery and not to be thrown off course by anything; good cheer in every circumstance, including illness; a character that mixed sweetness with dignity; and doing whatever lay before me without grumbling. Everyone trusted that he meant what he said and acted with good intentions. He was never astonished, never in a hurry, never put things off; he was never at a loss, never downcast, never forced a laugh to cover irritation, and never flew into anger or suspicion. He was generous, forgiving, and honest, and gave the impression of a man who had always been upright rather than one who had had to be corrected. No one could ever feel looked down on by him, or imagine himself the better man — and he had a gift for being agreeably funny.

16 In my adoptive father, Antoninus, I saw gentleness and an unshakable commitment to decisions made after careful thought. He was indifferent to the so-called honors people crave; he loved hard work and persistence, and was open

to anyone with a proposal for the common good. He gave every man exactly what he deserved, and he knew from experience when to press hard and when to ease off. He thought of himself as no more than an ordinary citizen, and he freed his friends from any obligation to dine with him or attend him on his travels; those kept away by other duties always found him unchanged. In council he examined matters carefully and patiently, never breaking off too soon, satisfied with first impressions. He kept his friends without tiring of them and without being extravagantly attached. He was content in every situation, cheerful, and farsighted, attending to the smallest details without fuss. He put a stop to flattery and applause aimed at himself. He watched constantly over what the empire needed, managed its spending well, and patiently bore the criticism this drew. He was neither superstitious toward the gods nor a courter of popular favor; he was sober and steady in everything, never vulgar, never chasing novelty. The comforts that fortune supplied in abundance he used without arrogance and without apology — enjoying them naturally when they were there, and not missing them when they were gone. No one could call him a sophist, a glib servant, or a pedant; everyone recognized him as a mature, complete man, beyond flattery, able to govern himself and others. He honored genuine philosophers and did not reproach the false ones, though he was never taken in by them. He was easy in conversation and charming without being tiresome. He cared for his health sensibly — not clinging to life or fussing over his looks, yet not neglecting himself — so that he rarely needed a doctor. He was quick to make way for those with real talent, in eloquence, law, ethics, or anything else, and helped each win the recognition he deserved. He followed his country's

traditions without making a show of it. He disliked change and restlessness, preferring the same places and pursuits, and after his bouts of headache he came back fresh and vigorous to his work. He kept few secrets, and only about public affairs. He was prudent and economical in staging public shows, putting up buildings, and making gifts to the people — a man who looked to what ought to be done, not to the reputation it would earn. He did not bathe at odd hours, did not build for the sake of building, and was indifferent to his food and to the cut and color of his clothes. There was nothing harsh in him, nothing relentless or violent, nothing ‘driven to the sweating point’; he examined everything calmly, as if he had all the time in the world — orderly, steady, and consistent. What was said of Socrates fits him: he could go without the things most people cannot do without, and enjoy in moderation the things most people cannot enjoy without overdoing it. To be strong enough for both — to do without, and to enjoy with restraint — is the mark of a man whose soul is balanced and unbeatable, exactly as he showed during Maximus’ illness.

17 To the gods I owe good grandfathers, good parents, a good sister, good teachers, good companions, good relatives and friends — almost everything good. I owe it to them, too, that I never lost my temper and wronged any of them, though my nature was such that, given the chance, I might have; by their grace, the circumstances that would have tested me never came together. I am grateful that I was not raised too long by my father’s mistress; that I kept my innocence and did not become a man before my time, but if anything waited longer than I needed to. I lived under a ruler and father who stripped away my pride and showed

me that one can live in a palace without bodyguards, fine clothes, torches, statues, and such display, and can bring oneself nearly to the level of a private citizen without becoming, for that reason, any smaller in spirit or any slacker in the public duties a ruler must perform. The gods gave me a brother whose character spurred me to watch over myself, and whose respect and affection gladdened me; children who were not born dull or deformed; and the good sense not to get further in rhetoric and poetry and other studies that might have absorbed me had I felt I was excelling. I was quick to give those who raised me the honors they seemed to want, instead of putting them off with promises because they were still young. I came to know Apollonius, Rusticus, and Maximus. I formed clear and frequent pictures of what it means to live according to nature, so that, as far as the gods and their gifts and help and inspiration were concerned, nothing kept me from living that way at once — though I still fall short through my own fault, by not heeding their reminders and almost explicit instructions. My body has held out this long in such a life. I never laid a hand on Benedicta or Theodotus, and when I later fell into infatuations, I recovered. Though I was often annoyed with Rusticus, I never went so far as to do something I would regret. My mother, though fated to die young, spent her last years with me. Whenever I wanted to help someone in need, I was never told there was no money for it — and I myself never had to ask such help from anyone. I have a wife so obedient, affectionate, and unaffected; and I had no shortage of good teachers for my children. Remedies were shown to me in dreams, including ones for spitting blood and for dizziness. And when I was drawn to philosophy, I did not fall into the hands of some sophist, or waste my

time on historical writers, on untangling logical puzzles, or on speculating about the heavens. For all of these, I needed the help of the gods and of fortune.

BOOK

II

Written on campaign, these notes brace him for difficult people and his own mortality. Expect the famous morning resolution that he will meet the ungrateful and arrogant today, and the reminder that he is only flesh, breath, and a ruling mind.

1 Begin each morning by telling yourself: today I will meet people who are meddling, ungrateful, arrogant, dishonest, envious, and unsociable. They are like this because they cannot tell good from evil. But I have seen that the nature of the good is beautiful and the nature of the bad is ugly, and that the one who does wrong is related to me—not by blood or birth, but because we share the same mind and the same fragment of the divine. So none of them can truly harm me, since no one can force me into anything ugly, and I cannot be angry with a relative or hate him. We were made to work together, like the feet, the hands, the eyelids, the rows of upper and lower teeth. To work against one another, then, is against nature—and resentment and turning away are exactly that.

2 Whatever I am, I am just a little flesh and breath and the part that governs. Put your books aside; stop letting them distract you—you are not allowed that anymore. Instead, as though you were already dying, look down on the flesh: it is just blood and bones, a mesh of nerves, veins, and arteries. Look at the breath, too, and see what it is—air, never the same, breathed out and sucked back in every moment. The third thing is the governing part. Think of it this way: you are an old man now. Stop letting it be a slave. Stop letting it be jerked around like a puppet by unsociable impulses. Stop being dissatisfied with what the present holds, or flinching from what the future brings.

3 Everything that comes from the gods is full of providence. Even what comes from chance is not cut off from nature, but woven and tangled together with the things providence arranges. Everything flows from that source. And there is also necessity, and what serves the good of the whole universe, of which you are a part. Whatever the nature of the whole brings is good for each of its parts, and whatever keeps that nature going is good too. The universe is kept alive by the changes of the elements, and also by the changes of the things made from those elements. Let these principles be enough for you; hold them always as settled convictions. And throw away your thirst for books, so that you do not die complaining, but cheerfully, sincerely, and truly grateful to the gods from your heart.

4 Remember how long you have been putting these things off, and how many chances the gods have given you that you still do not use. It is time, at last, to grasp what universe you are part of, and that your existence flows from the one who administers that universe, and that a limit has been set

on your time. If you do not use that time to clear the clouds from your mind, it will pass—and you will pass with it—and it will never come back.

5 Every moment, set yourself firmly, as a Roman and a man, to do the task in front of you with perfect and simple dignity, with affection, freedom, and justice, and to free yourself from every other thought. You will free yourself if you do each act of your life as if it were your last—setting aside all carelessness, all passionate resistance to what reason commands, all hypocrisy, all self-love, and all discontent with the lot you have been given. See how few things a man needs to master in order to live a calm life, like the life of the gods; for the gods themselves will ask nothing more from anyone who keeps to these things.

6 You wrong yourself, you wrong yourself, my soul—and soon you will no longer have the chance to honor yourself. Every person gets just one life, and yours is nearly over, yet you still do not respect yourself; instead you stake your happiness on the souls of other people.

7 Do the things happening around you pull you in every direction? Then give yourself time to learn something new and good, and stop spinning. But beware of being swept off in the other direction too; for those who wear themselves out with constant activity are just as foolish if they have no goal to aim every action—and indeed every thought—toward.

8 A man is rarely seen to be unhappy because he failed to notice what was in someone else's mind; but those who fail to watch the movements of their own minds are bound to be unhappy.

9 Always keep this in mind: what the nature of the whole is, what my own nature is, how mine relates to the whole, what kind of part it is and of what kind of whole—and that no one can stop you from always acting and speaking in keeping with the nature you are part of.

10 When Theophrastus compares wrongdoings—the kind of comparison one would make according to ordinary human ideas—he says, like a true philosopher, that offenses committed out of desire are more blameworthy than those committed out of anger. For the man stirred by anger seems to turn away from reason with a kind of pain and an unwilling flinch; but the man who offends out of desire is overcome by pleasure and seems somehow more lacking in self-control, more weak-willed in his wrongdoing. Rightly, then, and in a way worthy of philosophy, he said that the offense committed with pleasure deserves more blame than the one committed with pain. On the whole, the angry man is like someone who was first wronged and is driven by pain into anger, while the other moves on his own impulse to do wrong, carried into action by desire.

11 Since it is possible that you may leave this life at any moment, govern every action and thought accordingly. As for leaving the company of people, if there are gods, there is nothing to fear—they will not let you fall into evil. And if there are no gods, or if they take no interest in human affairs, then why would I want to live in a universe with no gods and no providence? But in truth they do exist, and they do care about human things, and they have placed everything within a man's power so that he need not fall into real evils. As for anything else, if it were truly evil, they would have arranged that too, so that it would be entirely in

a man's power to avoid it. And anything that does not make a man worse—how could it make his life worse? It is not possible that the nature of the universe overlooked these things out of ignorance, nor out of knowing them while lacking the power to guard against or correct them. Nor is it possible that it made so great a mistake, through weakness or lack of skill, that good and evil should fall on the good and the bad alike. But death and life, honor and dishonor, pain and pleasure—all of these come equally to good men and bad, and they make us neither better nor worse. So they are neither good nor evil.

12 How quickly everything vanishes—the bodies themselves into the universe, and the memory of them into time. Consider the nature of all the things we sense, especially those that lure us with the bait of pleasure, or terrify us with pain, or are trumpeted about by empty fame: how worthless, contemptible, shabby, perishable, and dead they are. It is the work of the mind to observe all this—to observe, too, who these people really are whose opinions and voices grant reputation, and what death is. If a man looks at death by itself, and uses reflection to strip away everything the imagination piles onto it, he will see it as nothing more than a process of nature; and to be afraid of a process of nature is childish. And death is not only a process of nature, but something that serves nature's purposes. Observe, too, how man draws near to the divine, by what part of himself, and when that part is rightly disposed.

13 Nothing is more pitiable than a man who circles around everything, prying into what lies beneath the earth, as the poet says, and trying to guess by conjecture what is in his neighbors' minds, never realizing that it is enough to attend

to the spirit within himself and to revere it sincerely. To revere that spirit means keeping it free from passion and thoughtlessness, and from discontent with what comes from gods and men. What comes from the gods deserves reverence for its excellence; what comes from men should be dear to us because they are our kin—and sometimes, in a way, they even move us to pity because they do not know good from bad, a defect no smaller than the one that robs a person of the power to tell white from black.

14 Even if you were going to live for three thousand years, or ten thousand times that long, still remember this: no one loses any life but the one he is living now, and no one lives any life but the one he is losing now. So the longest life and the shortest come to the same thing. The present moment is the same for everyone, even though what is passing away is not the same for each; and so what is lost turns out to be only a moment. For a man cannot lose either the past or the future—how can anyone take from him what he does not have? Keep two things in mind, then. First, that all things from eternity have the same forms and come round again in a circle, so it makes no difference whether a man sees the same things for a hundred years, or two hundred, or forever. Second, that the longest-lived man and the one who dies soonest lose exactly the same. For the present is the only thing a man can be deprived of, since it is the only thing he has—and a man cannot lose what he does not have.

15 Remember that everything is a matter of opinion. The saying of Monimus the Cynic makes this plain, and the use of it is plain too, if a man takes from it as much as is true.

16 The soul of a man does violence to itself, first of all, when it becomes, as far as it can, an abscess or a kind of tumor on

the universe. For to be vexed at anything that happens is to cut yourself off from nature, which contains the natures of all other things in its various parts. Second, the soul does violence to itself when it turns away from another person, or moves toward him meaning to do harm, as the souls of angry people do. Third, when it is overpowered by pleasure or pain. Fourth, when it puts on an act, doing or saying anything insincerely or untruthfully. Fifth, when it lets any of its own acts or impulses have no aim, doing things thoughtlessly without considering what they are—when even the smallest things ought to be done with an end in view; and the end of rational beings is to follow the reason and the law of the most ancient city and commonwealth.

17 In human life, time is a mere point, the substance is in constant flux, perception is dim, the whole body is matter bound to rot, the soul is a whirl, fortune is hard to predict, and fame is mindless. In a word, everything of the body is a flowing stream, everything of the soul is dream and vapor, life is a war and a stranger's brief stay, and lasting fame is oblivion. What, then, can guide a man? One thing, and one thing only: philosophy. And this means keeping the spirit within him free from violence and unharmed, above pleasures and pains, doing nothing without a purpose and nothing falsely or with pretense, not depending on whether another man does or does not do something; and besides this, accepting everything that happens and everything allotted to him as coming from wherever he himself came; and, finally, awaiting death with a cheerful mind, since it is nothing but the breaking up of the elements that make up every living being. But if it does no harm to the elements themselves to be continually changing one into another,

why should a man dread the change and dissolution of them all? It is in keeping with nature, and nothing that is in keeping with nature is evil.

B O O K

III

*A meditation on time running out and on living well now.
He urges urgency before the mind itself fades, and finds an
unexpected beauty in ordinary, imperfect things when seen
clearly.*

1 We should keep in mind not only that our life is wearing away day by day, with less and less of it left, but also this: even if we live longer, there is no guarantee that the mind will stay sharp enough to understand things and keep the power of reflection that strives to grasp what is divine and what is human. For once a person slips into senility, the breathing and digestion and imagination and appetite and all the rest will keep working, but the power to make full use of ourselves, to fulfill our duty completely, to sort out every impression clearly, to judge whether the time has come to leave life, and everything else that requires a trained reason, all of that is already extinguished. So we must hurry, not only because we draw closer to death every day, but because the grasp and understanding of things gives out first.

2 We should also notice that even the byproducts of natural processes have a certain charm and attractiveness. When bread is baked, for instance, some parts crack open at the surface, and these cracks, though they happen contrary to the baker's intention, are beautiful in their own way and somehow whet the appetite. Likewise figs split open when fully ripe; and in ripe olives the very nearness to rotting lends the fruit a peculiar beauty. The drooping ears of grain, the lion's brow, the foam dripping from a wild boar's mouth, and many other things, though far from beautiful if you examine them on their own, still add to the charm of the natural things they accompany and please the mind. So anyone with real feeling and deeper insight into what is produced in the universe will find that scarcely one of these secondary effects fails to seem pleasingly arranged. He will look at the actual gaping jaws of wild beasts with no less pleasure than at those painters and sculptors imitate; he will see in an old woman and an old man a kind of ripeness and grace; and he will be able to look on the appealing loveliness of the young with chaste eyes. Many such things will present themselves, pleasing not to everyone, but only to the person who has become truly familiar with Nature and her works.

3 Hippocrates cured many diseases, then fell sick and died himself. The Chaldean astrologers foretold the deaths of many, and then fate caught up with them too. Alexander, Pompey, and Gaius Caesar, after wiping out whole cities again and again and cutting to pieces tens of thousands of cavalry and infantry in battle, themselves at last departed from life. Heraclitus, after all his theories about the universe going up in flames, filled up with water inside and

died smeared all over with mud. Lice killed Democritus, and other vermin killed Socrates. What does all this mean? You boarded the ship, you made the voyage, you have reached shore: get off. If it is to another life, there is no lack of gods even there; and if it is to a state without sensation, you will no longer be held by pains and pleasures, no longer a slave to this vessel, the body, which is as far inferior to what it serves as a servant is to its master. For the one is intelligence and divinity, the other is earth and decay.

4 Do not waste what remains of your life in thoughts about other people, unless you are relating those thoughts to some common good. For you lose the chance to do something else when you let your mind run on things like this: what is so-and-so doing, and why, and what is he saying, and what is he thinking, and what is he scheming, and everything of that kind that pulls you away from watching your own ruling power. So in the run of your thoughts you should cut out everything aimless and useless, and above all the over-curious and the spiteful. Train yourself to think only of things such that, if someone suddenly asked you, ‘What are you thinking about right now?’, you could answer at once and openly, ‘This’ or ‘That’, and it would be plain from your words that everything in you is straightforward and kind, the thoughts of a social creature, one with no concern for pleasure or sensual indulgence at all, no rivalry, no envy, no suspicion, nothing you would blush to admit was on your mind. A person like this, who no longer puts off being among the best, is a kind of priest and servant of the gods, using too the divinity seated within him, which keeps a man uncontaminated by pleasure, unhurt by any pain, untouched by any insult, immune to wrong, a fighter in the

noblest of fights, one who cannot be overpowered by any passion, steeped deep in justice, welcoming with his whole soul everything that happens and is assigned to him as his share. He rarely, and only out of great necessity and for the common good, lets himself imagine what someone else is saying or doing or thinking. He takes only what is his own as the material for his action; he keeps in mind what has been allotted to him out of the sum of things; he makes his own conduct fair; and he is convinced that his own portion is good. For the lot assigned to each person is carried along with him and carries him along with it. He also remembers that every rational being is his kin, that caring for all people is in keeping with human nature, and that he should hold on to the opinions not of everyone, but only of those who admittedly live according to nature. As for those who do not live so, he keeps in mind what sort of people they are at home and abroad, by night and by day, and what they are, and with what company they lead their impure lives. So he sets no value at all on the praise of such men, since they are not even satisfied with themselves.

5 Do not work unwillingly, nor without regard for the common good, nor without careful thought, nor in a distracted way. Do not dress up your thoughts with studied ornament. Do not be a man of many words or one who busies himself with too many things. And further, let the divinity within you be the guardian of a being who is manly and mature, engaged in public affairs, a Roman, and a ruler, one who has taken up his post like a man waiting for the signal that calls him out of life, ready to go, needing no oath and no one else's testimony. Be cheerful, too, and do not look outside yourself for help or for the peace of mind that others give.

A man should stand upright on his own, not be propped up by others.

6 If you find in human life anything better than justice, truth, self-control, and courage; in short, anything better than your own mind's contentment in the things it lets you do according to right reason, and in your contentment with the lot assigned to you without your own choosing; if, I say, you see anything better than this, then turn to it with all your soul and enjoy what you have found to be best. But if nothing appears better than the divinity planted within you, which has brought all your appetites under its control, which scrutinizes every impression, which has, as Socrates said, detached itself from the persuasions of the senses, submitted itself to the gods, and made the welfare of mankind its care; if you find everything else smaller and of less worth than this, then give way to nothing else. For once you swerve and lean toward something else, you will no longer be able, without distraction, to give first place to that good thing that is properly and uniquely your own. It is not right that anything of a different kind, such as the praise of the crowd, or power, or the enjoyment of pleasure, should compete with what is good in the rational and social sense. All these things, even if they seem to fit in only slightly, suddenly gain the upper hand and sweep us away. So you, I say, must simply and freely choose the better and hold to it. But the useful is the better. Well then, if it is useful to you as a rational being, keep to it; but if it is useful only to you as an animal, say so, and hold to your judgment without arrogance, only taking care to make the inquiry by a sound method.

7 Never value as good for yourself anything that would force you to break a promise, to lose your self-respect, to hate anyone, to grow suspicious, to curse, to play the hypocrite, or to crave anything that needs walls and curtains to hide it. The man who has put his own intelligence and inner divinity, and the honoring of its excellence, above everything else plays no tragic role, does not groan, and will need neither solitude nor a crowd. Best of all, he will live without either chasing death or running from it. Whether his soul is to be enclosed in the body for a longer or a shorter time makes no difference to him at all; even if he must depart at once, he will go as readily as if turning to any other task that can be done decently and in order, caring all through life about only this: that his mind never turns away from anything that belongs to a thinking creature and a member of a community.

8 In the mind of a man who has been disciplined and purified you will find nothing rotten, no foulness, no sore merely scabbed over. Fate does not catch his life unfinished, as one might say of an actor who leaves the stage before the play is over and done. And there is nothing in him servile, nothing affected, nothing too tightly bound to other things nor yet cut off from them, nothing that deserves blame, nothing that looks for a place to hide.

9 Revere the faculty that forms opinions. Everything depends on it, whether or not there will arise in your ruling part any opinion out of keeping with nature and the constitution of a rational being. This faculty promises freedom from hasty judgment, friendship toward others, and obedience to the gods.

10 So throw everything else away and hold on to these few things only. And remember as well that each of us lives only in the present moment, this indivisible point of time, and that all the rest of our life is either past or uncertain. Short, then, is the time anyone lives, and small the corner of the earth where he lives, and short too the longest fame after death, kept alive only by a succession of poor mortals who will die very soon themselves, and who do not even know their own selves, much less someone who died long ago.

11 To the aids already mentioned let this one be added: make for yourself a definition or description of whatever is presented to you, so that you can see clearly what kind of thing it is in its essence, stripped bare, in its full reality, and can name it properly, and name the parts of which it is composed and into which it will dissolve. Nothing lifts the mind so much as being able to examine, methodically and truthfully, every object that comes up in life, and always to look at things in such a way as to see at the same time what kind of universe this is, what purpose each thing serves in it, what value it has in relation to the whole and what value in relation to man, who is a citizen of the highest city, of which all other cities are like households. Ask what each thing is, what it is made of, how long it is in its nature to last, this thing that now makes an impression on me, and what virtue I need to meet it, such as gentleness, courage, truthfulness, loyalty, simplicity, self-sufficiency, and the rest. So on every occasion a man should say: this comes from god; and this comes by the apportioning and spinning of the thread of destiny, by such coincidence and chance; and this comes from one of my own kind, a kinsman and partner, who does not know, however, what accords with his nature.

But I know; and for that reason I treat him, according to the natural law of fellowship, with kindness and justice. At the same time, in things that are neither good nor bad, I try to gauge the worth of each.

12 If you work at the task before you, following right reason in earnest, with vigor and calm, letting nothing else distract you, but keeping your divine part pure as though you might have to give it back at any moment; if you hold to this, expecting nothing, fearing nothing, but content with your present activity in accordance with nature, and with heroic truthfulness in every word and sound you utter, then you will live happily. And there is no one who can stop you.

13 Just as doctors always keep their instruments and scalpels ready for cases that suddenly call for their skill, so you should keep your principles ready for understanding things divine and human, and for doing everything, even the smallest thing, mindful of the bond that links the divine and the human to each other. For you will do nothing well in human affairs without at the same time keeping the divine in view, and nothing well in divine affairs without keeping the human in view.

14 Do not drift aimlessly any longer. You are not going to read your own notebooks now, nor the deeds of the ancient Romans and Greeks, nor the selections from books you were saving up for old age. So hurry to the goal before you, throw away idle hopes, and come to your own rescue, if you care about yourself at all, while it is still in your power.

15 People do not realize how many things are meant by the words stealing, sowing, buying, keeping quiet, seeing what ought to be done; for this last is not done with the eyes but by another kind of sight.

16 Body, soul, intelligence: to the body belong sensations, to the soul appetites, to the intelligence principles. To receive impressions of forms through appearances belongs even to animals. To be jerked about by the strings of desire belongs both to wild beasts and to men who have turned themselves into women, and to a Phalaris and a Nero. And to have the intelligence that points the way to what seems fitting belongs even to those who do not believe in the gods, who betray their country, and who do their foul deeds behind shut doors. If, then, everything else is shared by all those I have mentioned, what remains as peculiar to the good man is this: to be pleased and content with whatever happens, and with the thread spun for him; not to defile the divinity seated in his breast nor disturb it with a crowd of images, but to keep it serene, following it obediently as a god, never saying anything contrary to the truth nor doing anything contrary to justice. And if everyone refuses to believe that he lives a simple, modest, and contented life, he is not angry with any of them, nor does he stray from the road that leads to the end of life, to which a man ought to come pure, tranquil, ready to depart, and without compulsion perfectly reconciled to his lot.

B O O K

IV

One of the richest books, turning on the idea that you can retreat into your own soul anywhere for peace. Themes of impermanence, the constant change of all things, and acting with purpose run throughout.

- 1 The part of us that rules from within, when it is in accord with nature, takes whatever happens so readily that it always adapts itself to whatever is possible and is set before it. It needs no particular material to work with; it moves toward its purpose, though under certain conditions, and it turns whatever opposes it into material for itself, the way a fire seizes what falls into it. A small flame would be smothered, but a strong fire quickly takes hold of whatever is piled onto it, consumes it, and rises higher because of that very fuel.
- 2 Let nothing be done without a purpose, and nothing except according to the perfect principles of the craft.
- 3 People look for places to get away to: country houses, beaches, mountains. You too long for such things very much. But this is the mark of the most ordinary kind of

person, since it is in your power, whenever you choose, to retreat into yourself. Nowhere can you find a more peaceful or untroubled retreat than in your own soul, especially when you have within you the kind of thoughts that, by simply looking into them, put you at once into complete tranquillity. And by tranquillity I mean nothing other than a well-ordered mind. So give yourself this retreat constantly, and renew yourself. Keep your principles brief and basic, so that the moment you turn to them they are enough to wash the soul clean and send you back free of all discontent with the things you are returning to. For what is it you are discontented with? With people's wickedness? Then call to mind the conclusion that rational beings exist for one another, that patience is a part of justice, and that people do wrong without meaning to. Consider how many, after their mutual hostility, suspicion, hatred, and fighting, have been laid out dead and reduced to ashes; and be at peace at last. Or perhaps you are dissatisfied with the portion the universe has assigned you. Then recall the alternative: either there is providence, or there are only atoms, a chance jumble of things; or remember the arguments that have proved the world to be a kind of political community; and be at peace at last. Or perhaps bodily things still take hold of you. Then consider further that the mind does not mingle with the breath, whether it moves gently or violently, once it has drawn itself apart and discovered its own power; and remember all you have heard and agreed to about pain and pleasure; and be at peace at last. Or perhaps the desire for what is called fame will torment you. Then see how quickly everything is forgotten; look at the chaos of infinite time on either side of the present, at the emptiness of applause, at the fickleness and poor judgment of those who pretend

to give praise, and at the narrowness of the space within which praise is confined. For the whole earth is a mere point, and how tiny a corner of it is this home of yours, and how few people are in it, and what kind of people are those who will praise you.

4 This, then, is what remains: remember to retreat into this little domain of your own, and above all do not strain or distract yourself, but stay free, and look at things as a man, as a human being, as a citizen, as a mortal. Among the things readiest at hand, to which you should turn, let there be these two. The first is that things do not touch the soul; they stand outside it, unmoving, and our disturbances come only from the opinion within us. The second is that all the things you see are changing this very moment and will soon be no more; keep constantly in mind how many such changes you have already witnessed. The universe is transformation; life is opinion.

5 If the thinking part of us is shared, then so is the reason that makes us rational beings. If that is so, then the reason which commands us what to do and what not to do is also shared. If that is so, there is a common law as well. If that is so, we are fellow citizens. If that is so, we are members of some political community. If that is so, the world is in a way a state. For what other common community could anyone claim that the whole human race belongs to? And it is from this common community that our very power of thought, our reasoning, and our capacity for law come; or where else would they come from? Just as my earthly part is a portion given to me from a certain earth, my watery part from another element, and my hot, fiery part from some particular source (for nothing comes out of nothing, just as

nothing returns to non-existence), so too the thinking part comes from some source.

6 Death is like birth, a mystery of nature: a combining of the same elements and a dissolving back into the same. It is nothing anyone should be ashamed of, for it is not contrary to the nature of a reasoning creature, nor contrary to the design of our constitution.

7 It is natural that such things should be done by such people; it is inevitable. If a man refuses to allow it, he might as well refuse to let the fig tree have its juice. By all means keep this in mind: within a very short time both you and he will be dead, and soon not even your names will remain.

8 Take away your opinion, and you take away the complaint, "I have been harmed." Take away the complaint, "I have been harmed," and the harm itself is gone.

9 Whatever does not make a man worse than he was also does not make his life worse, and does not harm him, either from outside or from within.

10 The nature of what is universally useful has been compelled to act this way.

11 Consider that everything which happens, happens justly, and if you observe carefully you will find this to be so. I do not mean merely with respect to the orderly sequence of events, but with respect to justice, as though done by someone who assigns to each thing its due. So keep observing as you have begun, and whatever you do, do it together with this aim: being good, in the sense in which a man is properly understood to be good. Hold to this in every action.

12 Do not take the same view of things that the person who wrongs you holds, or the view he wishes you to hold; but look at them as they truly are.

13 A man should always keep these two rules ready at hand. The first is to do only what the reason of the ruling and law-giving faculty suggests for the benefit of people. The second is to change your opinion if someone is at hand to set you right and move you from a mistaken view. But this change of mind must come only from a genuine conviction, of what is just or for the common good or the like, not because it seems pleasant or brings you a good reputation.

14 Do you have reason? I do. Then why not use it? For if reason does its own work, what more could you want?

15 You have existed as a part of the whole. You will disappear back into what produced you; or rather, you will be taken back, through transformation, into its generative principle.

16 Many grains of incense fall on the same altar; one falls sooner, another later, but it makes no difference.

17 Within ten days you will seem a god to the very people who now regard you as a beast and an ape, if you will return to your principles and to the worship of reason.

18 Do not act as though you were going to live ten thousand years. Death hangs over you. While you are alive, while it is still in your power, be good.

19 How much trouble a man avoids who does not look to see what his neighbor says or does or thinks, but only to what he himself does, that it may be just and pure. As Agathon says, do not glance around at the corrupt char-

acters of others, but run straight along the line without swerving from it.

20 The man who has a fierce desire for fame after death does not consider that every one of those who remember him will himself soon die, and then those who succeed them, until the whole memory of him is snuffed out as it passes through people who admire foolishly and then perish. But suppose that those who remember you were even immortal, and the memory itself immortal: what is that to you? And I do not even ask what it is to the dead, but what it is to the living. What is praise, except so far as it has some practical use? For now you are unreasonably rejecting the gift of nature, clinging instead to something else.

21 Everything that is in any way beautiful is beautiful in itself and complete in itself; praise is no part of it. Being praised makes a thing neither worse nor better. I say this even of the things commonly called beautiful, such as material objects and works of art. What is truly beautiful needs nothing beyond itself, no more than law does, or truth, or kindness, or modesty. Which of these is made beautiful by being praised, or spoiled by being blamed? Is an emerald made worse than it was if no one praises it? Or gold, ivory, purple, a lyre, a little knife, a flower, a shrub?

22 If souls continue to exist, how does the air contain them from all eternity? But then how does the earth contain the bodies of those buried so long ago? For just as here the change of these bodies, after lasting however long, and their dissolution, make room for other dead bodies, so the souls that pass into the air, after lasting some time, are transformed and dispersed, and take on a fiery nature as they are received back into the generative intelligence of

the universe, and in this way make room for fresh souls coming to dwell there. This is the answer a man might give on the assumption that souls continue to exist. But we must think not only of the number of bodies that are buried, but also of the number of animals eaten each day by us and by other animals. What a multitude is consumed, and in a way buried in the bodies of those who feed on them! And yet the earth still receives them, through their changes into blood and their transformations into the airy or the fiery element.

23 What is the way to investigate the truth here? To divide a thing into what is material and what is the cause of its form.

24 Do not be spun about, but in every impulse have regard for justice, and at every impression preserve the power of clear understanding.

25 Everything that is in harmony with you, O Universe, is in harmony with me. Nothing is too early or too late for me that is in due time for you. Everything is fruit to me that your seasons bring, O Nature. From you are all things, in you are all things, to you all things return. The poet says, "Dear city of Cecrops"; will you not say, "Dear city of Zeus"?

26 Keep yourself occupied with few things, the philosopher says, if you would be tranquil. But consider whether it might not be better to say: do what is necessary, and whatever the reason of a creature naturally social requires, and as it requires. For this brings not only the tranquillity that comes from acting well, but also the tranquillity that comes from doing few things. Since the greater part of what we say and do is unnecessary, a man who strips that away will have more leisure and less disquiet. So on every occasion a man should ask himself: is this one of the unnecessary things? And he should strip away not only unnecessary actions but

also unnecessary thoughts, so that superfluous actions will not follow from them.

27 Try out how the life of a good man suits you, the man who is satisfied with the portion assigned to him out of the whole, and satisfied with his own just acts and kindly disposition.

28 Have you seen those things? Now look at these as well. Do not disturb yourself. Make yourself entirely simple. Does someone do wrong? It is to himself that he does the wrong. Has something happened to you? Very well; out of the universe, from the beginning, everything that happens has been apportioned and spun out for you. In short, your life is brief. You must turn the present to good account with the help of reason and justice. Be sober even in your relaxation.

29 Either this is a well-ordered universe, or it is a chaos thrown together; but a universe even so. Can there be order within you, yet disorder in the whole? And this when all things are so distinct, so spread out, and yet bound together in sympathy?

30 A black character, an unmanly one, a stubborn one, brutish, childish, animal, stupid, fraudulent, vulgar, deceitful, tyrannical.

31 If a man is a stranger to the universe because he does not know what is in it, he is no less a stranger because he does not know what is going on in it. He is a runaway who flees from the social reason. He is blind who shuts the eyes of his understanding. He is poor who has need of another and does not have within himself all that is useful for life. He is an abscess on the universe who withdraws and cuts himself off from the reason of our common nature out of

displeasure with what happens, for the same nature that produces these things also produced you. He is a fragment torn from the state who tears his own soul away from the soul of reasoning beings, which is one.

32 One philosopher is without a tunic, another without a book; here is yet another half naked. “I have no bread,” he says, “and still I hold to reason”; and I get no living from my learning, yet still I hold to my reason.

33 Love the craft you have learned, humble as it may be, and be content with it; and live out the rest of your life as one who has entrusted all that he has to the gods with his whole soul, making yourself neither the tyrant nor the slave of any man.

34 Consider, for instance, the times of Vespasian. You will see all the same things: people marrying, raising children, falling sick, dying, making war, feasting, trading, farming, flattering, stubbornly arrogant, suspicious, scheming, wishing some people dead, grumbling about the present, in love, hoarding treasure, craving a consulship, craving royal power. Well, that life of theirs no longer exists at all. Move on to the times of Trajan. Again, everything is the same; their life too is gone. In the same way look at the other ages of time and whole nations, and see how many, after great efforts, soon fell and dissolved into the elements. Above all you should think of those you have known yourself who wore themselves out over trivial things and neglected to do what their own nature required, to hold firmly to that and be content with it. And here you must remember that the attention given to each thing has its proper value and proportion. For thus you will not be dissatisfied, if you give to lesser matters no more attention than is fitting.

35 The words that were once familiar are now obsolete; and so too the names of those famous in old times are now in a way obsolete: Camillus, Caeso, Volesus, Leonnatus, and a little later Scipio and Cato, then Augustus, then Hadrian and Antoninus. For all things soon pass away and become a mere story, and complete oblivion soon buries them. And I say this of those who shone in some remarkable way. As for the rest, the moment they have breathed their last they are gone, and no one speaks of them. And to settle the matter, what even is an eternal memory? Nothing at all. What, then, is it that we ought to spend our serious effort on? This one thing: just thoughts, actions that serve the common good, words that never lie, and a disposition that gladly welcomes everything that happens, as necessary, as familiar, as flowing from a source and principle of the same kind.

36 Willingly give yourself up to Clotho, one of the Fates, and let her spin your thread into whatever she pleases.

37 Everything lasts only for a day, both the one who remembers and the thing remembered.

38 Observe constantly that all things come to pass through change, and train yourself to consider that the nature of the universe loves nothing so much as to change what exists and to make new things like them. For everything that exists is in a way the seed of what will come from it. But you think only of seeds cast into the earth or the womb; that is a very crude notion.

39 You will soon die, and you are still not simple, still not free of disturbances, still not without the suspicion that external things can harm you, still not kindly toward everyone, nor do you yet locate wisdom solely in acting justly.

40 Examine the ruling principles of people, even of the wise: what kinds of things they avoid, and what kinds they pursue.

41 What is evil for you does not reside in the ruling principle of another, nor in any change or alteration of your bodily covering. Where, then, is it? It is in that part of you which has the power to form opinions about evils. So let this power form no such opinions, and all is well. Even if what lies nearest to it, the poor body, is cut, burned, festering with pus and rot, still let the part that forms opinions about these things stay quiet; that is, let it judge that nothing is either bad or good which can happen equally to a bad man and a good one. For whatever happens equally to the man who lives contrary to nature and to the man who lives according to nature is neither according to nature nor contrary to it.

42 Constantly regard the universe as one living being, with one substance and one soul. Observe how all things refer back to its single awareness; how all things act with one impulse; how all things are co-operating causes of everything that exists; and observe too the continuous spinning of the thread and the weaving of the web.

43 You are a little soul carrying around a corpse, as Epictetus used to say.

44 It is no evil for things to undergo change, and no good for things to come into being as a result of change.

45 Time is like a river of all that happens, a violent current; for no sooner has a thing come into view than it is swept away, and another takes its place, and that too will be swept away.

46 Everything that happens is as familiar and well known as the rose in spring and the fruit in summer; for such are disease and death and slander and treachery and everything else that delights or vexes fools.

47 In the sequence of things, what comes after always fits aptly with what has gone before; for this sequence is not like a mere list of disconnected items joined only by necessity, but a rational connection. And just as all existing things are arranged together in harmony, so the things that come into being show no mere succession but a certain wonderful kinship.

48 Always remember the saying of Heraclitus, that the death of earth is to become water, the death of water to become air, the death of air to become fire, and so on in reverse. Think too of the man who forgets where the road leads, and how people quarrel with the very thing they are in most constant communion with, the reason that governs the universe; and how the things they meet with every day seem strange to them. Consider that we ought not to act and speak as though we were asleep, for even in sleep we seem to act and speak; and that we ought not to act and speak merely as we have been taught, like children repeating what they learned from their parents.

49 If some god told you that you would die tomorrow, or certainly the day after, you would not care much whether it was the third day or tomorrow, unless you were utterly small-minded, for how slight the difference is. So think it no great matter to die after as many years as you can name rather than tomorrow.

50 Think continually how many physicians are dead, after so often knitting their brows over the sick; how many

astrologers, after predicting other people's deaths with great pretension; how many philosophers, after endless discourses on death and immortality; how many warriors, after killing thousands; how many tyrants, who wielded their power over men's lives with terrible arrogance, as though they were immortal. Think how many whole cities have died, so to speak, Helice, Pompeii, Herculaneum, and countless others. Add to the count all whom you yourself have known, one after another. One man, after burying another, is laid out dead, and another buries him; and all this in a short time. In a word, always observe how fleeting and worthless human things are: what was a little mucus yesterday will be a mummy or ashes tomorrow. So pass through this small span of time in agreement with nature, and end your journey content, as an olive falls when it is ripe, blessing the nature that produced it and giving thanks to the tree on which it grew.

51 Be like the headland on which the waves break again and again, while it stands firm and tames the fury of the water around it.

52 "How unlucky I am, that this has happened to me." Not so; rather, "How lucky I am that, though this has happened to me, I remain free of pain, neither crushed by the present nor afraid of the future." For such a thing might have happened to anyone, but not everyone would have remained free of pain through it. So why call that a misfortune rather than calling this a good fortune? And do you in general call something a man's misfortune when it is not a departure from man's nature? And does a thing seem to you a departure from man's nature when it is not contrary to the will of that nature? Well, you know the will of nature. Will this

thing that has happened keep you from being just, great-souled, temperate, prudent, free from rash opinions and falsehood? Will it keep you from being modest, free, and from having everything else by whose presence a man's nature obtains all that is its own? Remember, then, on every occasion that leads you to distress, to apply this principle: this is not a misfortune, but to bear it nobly is good fortune.

53 It is a common but still a useful aid toward despising death to review those who have clung tenaciously to life. What more have they gained than those who died early? At any rate they lie in their tombs somewhere at last, Cadi-cianus, Fabius, Julianus, Lepidus, or anyone else like them, men who carried out many others to be buried and were then carried out themselves. The interval between birth and death is small in any case; and consider with how much trouble, in what company, and in what a feeble body it is laboriously passed. So do not regard life as a thing of any great value. Look at the vast stretch of time behind you, and at the time before you, another boundless expanse. In this infinity, what difference is there between the man who lives three days and the man who lives three generations?

54 Always take the short road, and the short road is the natural one. So say and do everything in keeping with the soundest reason. For such a purpose frees a man from troubles, from struggle, and from all scheming and showy display.

BOOK

V

Begins with the struggle to get out of bed and do the work you were made for. He examines duty, doing your nature's task without complaint, and accepting whatever the whole assigns you.

1 When you wake reluctantly in the morning, keep this thought ready: I am rising to do the work of a human being. Why should I be unhappy, if I am going to do the very things I exist for, the things I was brought into the world to do? Or was I made for this, to lie under the blankets and keep myself warm? But this is more pleasant. So were you made to take your pleasure, and not at all for action and effort? Don't you see the little plants, the little birds, the ants, the spiders, the bees all working together to put their own parts of the universe in order? And you are unwilling to do the work of a human being, and don't hurry to do what your own nature calls for? But I need rest too. You do. Yet nature has set limits to that, just as she has set limits to eating and drinking; and still you go past those limits, past what is enough, while in your work you do the opposite and stop

short of what you could do. So you don't really love yourself, for if you did, you would love your nature and what it wants. People who love their crafts wear themselves out working at them, forgetting to wash or eat; but you value your own nature less than the metalworker values his craft, or the dancer his dancing, or the money-lover his money, or the vain man his scrap of glory. When such people are gripped by a passion for something, they would rather not eat or sleep than fall short of perfecting what they care about. Are the acts that serve society so worthless in your eyes, so much less worthy of your effort?

2 How easy it is to push away and wipe out every impression that is troubling or out of place, and at once to be completely at peace.

3 Judge that every word and action which is in keeping with nature is fitting for you, and don't be turned aside by the blame that may follow from others, or by their talk. If a thing is good to do or say, don't consider it beneath you. Those people have their own guiding principle and follow their own impulse; pay no attention to that, but go straight ahead, following your own nature and the common nature, for the path of both is one and the same.

4 I make my way through the things that happen according to nature until I fall and come to rest, breathing out my breath into the same element I draw it from each day, and falling onto the same earth from which my father gathered the seed, my mother the blood, and my nurse the milk; the earth that for so many years has supplied me with food and drink, and that bears me up as I tread on it and put it to so many uses.

5 You say men cannot admire the sharpness of your wit. So be it. But there are many other qualities about which you cannot say, I am not formed by nature for them. So display those qualities that are entirely within your power: sincerity, dignity, endurance of hard work, indifference to pleasure, contentment with your lot and with little, kindness, frankness, no taste for excess, no triviality, greatness of soul. Don't you see how many qualities you could show right now, for which there is no excuse of natural incapacity or unfitness, and yet you still choose to stay below the mark? Or are you forced by some defect of nature to grumble, to be stingy, to flatter, to blame your poor body, to fawn on people, to make a great show of yourself, and to be so restless in your mind? No, by the gods, you could have been free of all this long ago. If you can truly be charged only with being somewhat slow and dull in understanding, then work at this too, instead of neglecting it or taking comfort in your dullness.

6 One man, when he has done another a service, is quick to put it on the books as a favor owed to him. Another doesn't go that far, but still privately counts the man as his debtor and is well aware of what he has done. A third, in a way, isn't even aware of what he has done; he is like a vine that has produced grapes and looks for nothing more once it has yielded its proper fruit. As a horse runs, a dog tracks game, a bee makes honey, so a man who has done a good deed doesn't call out for others to come and see, but moves on to the next deed, as the vine moves on to bear grapes again in season. So must a person be one of those who act this way without taking notice of it? Yes. But surely it is necessary to be aware of what one is doing, for it is said

to be the mark of the social creature to perceive that it is acting for society, and indeed to want its fellow to perceive it too. What you say is true, but you misunderstand the point being made, and for that very reason you will become one of those I described earlier, for even they are led astray by a certain show of reason. But if you will choose to grasp the real meaning of what is said, don't be afraid that you will therefore neglect any social act.

7 A prayer of the Athenians: Rain, rain, dear Zeus, on the plowed fields and plains of the Athenians. In truth, either we should not pray at all, or we should pray in just this simple and noble way.

8 Just as we understand what it means when we say that Asclepius prescribed for a man horseback riding, or cold baths, or going barefoot, so we must understand it when we say that the nature of the universe prescribed for a man disease, or loss of a limb, or loss of something, or anything else of the kind. In the first case, prescribed means roughly this: he ordered this for this man as something suited to bring about health; and in the second it means that what happens to each man is in some way fixed for him to fit his destiny. This is what we mean when we say that things suit us, just as builders say of the squared stones in walls or pyramids that they suit one another, when they fit together in some connection. For there is altogether one fitness, one harmony. And just as the universe is made up out of all bodies to be the body it is, so out of all the existing causes destiny is made up to be the cause it is. Even people who understand nothing of this grasp my meaning, for they say, Fate brought this on him. So this was brought to him, this was prescribed for him. Let us then accept these things as

we accept what Asclepius prescribes. Many of his prescriptions, too, are unpleasant, yet we accept them in hope of health. Let the carrying-out and completion of the things that the common nature judges good be regarded by you as on the same footing as your health. And so accept everything that happens, even if it seems unpleasant, because it leads to this: the health of the universe and the well-being and good fortune of Zeus, the universe itself. For he would not have brought on anyone what he has brought, if it were not useful for the whole. The nature of nothing whatever brings about anything unsuited to what it governs. So for two reasons you should be content with what happens to you: first, because it was done for you, prescribed for you, and in a way had reference to you, spun together with your destiny from the most ancient causes; and second, because even what comes to each man separately is, for the power that administers the universe, a cause of its well-being and completion, and indeed of its very continuance. For the integrity of the whole is maimed if you cut off anything at all from the connection and continuity of its parts or of its causes. And you do cut it off, as far as you can, when you are discontented, and in a way you try to do away with it.

9 Don't be disgusted, discouraged, or dissatisfied if you don't manage to do everything by sound principles. When you fail, go back and try again, and be content if most of what you do is consistent with human nature, and love the thing you return to. Don't go back to philosophy as if it were a stern master, but like a man with sore eyes who reaches for a bit of sponge and egg, or like another who applies a plaster, or a soak of water. That way you will not fail to obey reason, and you will find rest in it. Remember too that

philosophy asks only for what your nature asks; it is you who want something else that is not according to nature. But, you may object, what is more agreeable than what I am doing now? Yet isn't this the very way pleasure deceives us? Consider whether greatness of soul, freedom, simplicity, calm, and devotion are not more agreeable still. And what is more agreeable than wisdom itself, when you think of the sureness and easy flow of everything that depends on the powers of understanding and knowledge?

10 Things are so wrapped up and obscure that they have seemed to philosophers, and not a few of them, nor commonplace ones, altogether unintelligible; indeed even to the Stoics themselves they seem hard to understand. And every judgment we make is liable to change, for where is the man who never changes his mind? Turn your thoughts, then, to the objects themselves, and consider how short-lived and worthless they are, and how they may be owned by a filthy wretch, a prostitute, or a thief. Then turn to the characters of those who live with you, and you can hardly bear even the most agreeable of them, let alone bear yourself. In such darkness and filth, then, and in such a ceaseless flow of substance and time, of motion and things moved, I cannot imagine what there is worth prizing highly or even pursuing seriously. On the contrary, a man's duty is to comfort himself and wait for his natural dissolution without fretting at the delay, resting only in these principles: first, that nothing will happen to me that is not in keeping with the nature of the universe; and second, that it is in my power never to act against my god and the guiding spirit within me, for no one can force me to do so.

11 What am I now using my soul for? On every occasion I must ask myself this, and examine what I now have in this part of me that they call the ruling principle, and whose soul I now have: a child's, a young man's, a weak woman's, a tyrant's, a tame animal's, or a wild beast's?

12 What sort of things the many consider good, we can learn even from this. If a man conceived of certain things as truly good, such as practical wisdom, self-control, justice, and courage, then having first grasped these he could not bear to hear anything that did not square with what is truly good. But if a man has first conceived as good the things the many call good, he will listen and gladly accept as very apt the line of the comic poet. In this way even the many sense the difference. For if it were otherwise, the saying would give offense and be rejected when applied to true goods, while we accept it as fitting and witty when it is said of wealth and of the means to luxury and fame. So go on and ask whether we should value, and judge to be good, the very things to which, once conceived in the mind, the comic poet's words could aptly be applied, that the man who has them has, through sheer abundance, nowhere even to relieve himself.

13 I am made up of the formal and the material; and neither of these will perish into nothing, just as neither came into being out of nothing. Every part of me, then, will be changed into some part of the universe, and that in turn into another part of the universe, and so on forever. By such a change I too came to exist, and so did those who begot me, and so on back forever in the other direction. For nothing stops us from saying this, even if the universe is administered in fixed cycles.

14 Reason and the art of reasoning, philosophy, are powers sufficient unto themselves and their own works. They set out from a starting point of their own and make their way to the goal set before them; and that is why such acts are called right acts, a word that signifies they proceed by the right road.

15 None of these things should be called a man's, which do not belong to a man as man. They are not required of a man, nor does man's nature promise them, nor are they the means by which his nature reaches its end. Therefore man's end does not lie in these things, nor does what helps toward that end, and what helps toward it is what is good. Besides, if any of these things did belong to man, it would not be right for him to despise them and set himself against them; nor would a man deserve praise for showing that he had no need of them, nor would a man who went without any of them be good, if these things really were good. But in fact, the more a man strips himself of these things, or others like them, or the more patiently he bears being deprived of any of them, by just so much is he the better man.

16 Such as are your habitual thoughts, such also will your mind's character be, for the soul is dyed by its thoughts. Dye it, then, with a continuous run of thoughts like these: that wherever a man can live, there he can also live well. But suppose he must live in a palace; well then, he can live well in a palace too. And consider further that whatever a thing has been made for, that is what it has been made for, and that is what it is carried toward; and its end lies in what it is carried toward; and where the end is, there too lie the advantage and the good of each thing. Now the good for a reasoning creature is society, for it has been shown

above that we are made for society. Isn't it plain that the inferior exists for the sake of the superior? And living things are superior to lifeless ones, and among living things the superior are those that have reason.

17 To seek what is impossible is madness; and it is impossible for the bad not to do things of this kind.

18 Nothing happens to any man that he is not formed by nature to bear. The same things happen to another man, and either because he doesn't notice that they have happened, or because he wants to show greatness of spirit, he stands firm and remains unharmed. It is a disgrace, then, that ignorance and conceit should be stronger than wisdom.

19 Things in themselves do not touch the soul, not in the slightest; they have no access to the soul, and they cannot turn or move it. The soul alone turns and moves itself, and whatever judgments it sees fit to make, it makes for itself out of the things that present themselves to it.

20 In one respect a man is the thing nearest to me, in that I must do good to others and put up with them. But insofar as some men set themselves in the way of my proper actions, a man becomes to me one of the things that are indifferent, no less than the sun, the wind, or a wild beast. These may hinder my action, but they are no hindrance to my impulses and my disposition, which can act conditionally and adapt; for the mind turns and changes every obstacle to its activity into an aid, so that what was a hindrance becomes a help to action, and what blocks the road actually advances us along it.

21 Revere what is best in the universe, that which makes use of all things and directs all things. And in the same way

revere what is best in yourself, for it is of the same kind. In you too, this is the thing that makes use of everything else, and by this your life is directed.

22 What does no harm to the state does no harm to the citizen. Whenever something appears harmful, apply this rule: if the state is not harmed by it, neither am I. But if the state is harmed, do not be angry with the one who harms it; instead, show him where his error lies.

23 Think often of how swiftly things pass by and vanish, both the things that exist and the things that are being produced. For substance is like a river in continual flow, the activities of things are forever changing, and the causes work in countless ways; there is hardly anything that stands still. And consider this thing close at hand, the boundless abyss of past and future, in which all things disappear. How then is the man not a fool who is puffed up over such things, or tormented by them, and makes himself miserable? For they trouble him only for a time, and a short time at that.

24 Think of the universal substance, of which you are a very small part; and of universal time, of which a brief, indivisible moment has been allotted to you; and of destiny, of which you are how tiny a portion.

25 Does another do me wrong? Let him see to it. He has his own disposition and his own way of acting. For my part, I now have what the universal nature now wills me to have, and I do what my own nature now wills me to do.

26 Let the part of your soul that leads and governs stay undisturbed by the movements of the flesh, whether of pleasure or of pain. Let it not mingle with them, but keep itself separate and confine those feelings to their own parts of the body. But when these feelings rise up to the mind

through the natural sympathy that exists in a body that is all one, then do not try to resist the sensation, for it is natural; only do not let the ruling part add to the sensation the opinion that it is either good or bad.

27 Live with the gods. And he lives with the gods who constantly shows them that his soul is satisfied with what is assigned to him, and that it does all that the guiding spirit wishes, the spirit that Zeus has given to each man as his guardian and guide, a portion of himself. And this is each man's understanding and reason.

28 Are you angry with the man whose armpits stink? Are you angry with the man whose breath smells foul? What good will your anger do you? He has such a mouth, he has such armpits; from such things such an odor must come. But the man has reason, you say, and could, if he took the trouble, work out where he is offending. Good luck to you with that discovery. Well then, you too have reason: use your rational faculty to rouse him; show him his error, set him straight. If he listens, you will cure him, and there is no need of anger. Neither tragic actor nor prostitute.

29 As you intend to live once you have departed, so it is in your power to live here. But if men will not allow it, then leave life, yet as one who suffers no harm by it. The room is smoky, and I walk out. Why think this any great trouble? But so long as nothing of the kind drives me out, I stay, I am free, and no one shall stop me from doing what I choose; and I choose to act according to the nature of a rational and social creature.

30 The intelligence of the universe is social. Accordingly it has made the inferior things for the sake of the superior, and it has fitted the superior to one another. You see how

it has subordinated and coordinated them, assigning to each its proper portion, and bringing the best things into harmony with one another.

31 How have you behaved up to now toward the gods, toward your parents, brothers, children, teachers, toward those who cared for you in infancy, toward your friends, your relatives, your slaves? Consider whether up to now you have behaved toward them all in such a way that this could be said of you:

32 Never has he wronged a man in deed or word.

33 And call to mind how many things you have lived through, and how much you have been able to endure; that the story of your life is now complete and your service ended; how many beautiful things you have seen; how many pleasures and pains you have looked past; how many so-called honors you have spurned; and to how many ill-natured people you have shown a kind disposition.

34 Why do unskilled and ignorant souls disturb the one who has skill and knowledge? And what soul has skill and knowledge? The one that knows the beginning and the end, and knows the reason that runs through all substance and, throughout all time, administers the universe in fixed cycles.

35 Soon, very soon, you will be ashes or a skeleton, and either a name or not even a name; and a name is mere sound and echo. The things much prized in life are empty and rotten and trivial, like little dogs snapping at one another, or little children quarreling, laughing, and the next moment in tears. But loyalty and modesty and justice and truth have fled away,

36 up to Olympus from the wide-spread earth.

37 What, then, is left to keep you here, if the objects of sense are forever shifting and never stand still, if the organs of perception are dull and easily take in false impressions, and the poor soul itself is but a vapor risen from blood? To have a good reputation in such a world as this is an empty thing. Why then do you not wait calmly for your end, whether it be extinction or a passing into another state? And until that time comes, what is enough? Why, what else than to honor the gods and bless them, to do good to others, to practice tolerance and self-restraint; and as for everything beyond the bounds of this poor flesh and breath, to remember that it is neither yours nor in your power.

38 You can spend your life in an even flow of happiness, if you can go by the right road and think and act in the right way. These two things are common to the soul of God, to the soul of man, and to the soul of every rational being: not to be hindered by another, and to find the good in a disposition toward justice and the practice of it, and there to let your desire come to rest.

39 If this is not my own badness, nor the effect of my own badness, and the common good is not harmed by it, why am I troubled about it, and what is the harm to the common good?

40 Do not be carried away thoughtlessly by the appearance of things, but give help to all according to your ability and their need; and if they have suffered loss in matters that are indifferent, do not imagine this to be real damage, for that is a bad habit. But just as the old man, when he was leaving, asked back his foster-child's top, remembering all the while that it was only a top, so do you act in this case too.

41 When you are out there declaiming on the public platform, have you forgotten, man, what these things really are? Yes, but they matter greatly to these people. Will you then let yourself be made a fool of along with them? I was once a fortunate man, but I lost it, I don't know how. But fortunate means a man who has assigned himself a good lot, and a good lot is a good disposition of the soul, good impulses, good actions.

BOOK

VI

Short, sharp reflections on the orderly reason that governs the universe and on duty done without fuss. A recurring note: the best revenge is simply not to become like the person who wronged you.

- 1 The substance of the universe is obedient and yielding, and the reason that governs it has in itself no cause to do evil, for it holds no malice, does evil to nothing, and harms nothing. All things are made and brought to completion according to this reason.
- 2 Let it make no difference to you whether you are cold or warm, as long as you are doing your duty; whether you are drowsy or fully rested; whether spoken ill of or praised; whether dying or doing something else. For dying is one of the acts of life, and in this act too it is enough to do well what we have in hand.
- 3 Look within. Do not let the particular quality of anything, or its worth, escape you.

- 4 All existing things change soon, and they will either be reduced to vapor, if indeed all substance is one, or else they will be scattered.
- 5 The reason that governs knows its own disposition, what it does, and the material on which it works.
- 6 The best way to avenge yourself is not to become like the wrongdoer.
- 7 Take pleasure and rest in one thing: in passing from one act done for others to another act done for others, with God in your thoughts.
- 8 The ruling part of you is what rouses and turns itself; it makes itself such as it is and such as it wills to be, and it also makes everything that happens appear to itself as it wills.
- 9 Every single thing is brought to completion in accordance with the nature of the universe; for it cannot be in accordance with any other nature that each thing is accomplished, neither a nature that contains this one from outside, nor a nature contained within it, nor a nature external to it and independent.
- 10 The universe is either confusion, things tangled together and scattered apart, or else it is unity, order, and providence. If it is the former, why do I wish to linger in a random jumble of things, in such disorder? Why should I care about anything except how I shall at last become earth? And why am I disturbed, since my elements will be scattered whatever I do? But if the other view is true, then I revere, I stand firm, and I trust in the one who governs.
- 11 When circumstances have forced you into some disturbance, return quickly to yourself, and do not stay out of tune any longer than the compulsion lasts; for you will gain

greater mastery over the harmony by continually coming back to it.

12 If you had a stepmother and a mother at the same time, you would do your duty by the stepmother, yet you would constantly return to your mother. Let the court and philosophy now be your stepmother and your mother: return to philosophy often and find rest in her, for through her what you meet with at court becomes bearable to you, and you become bearable at court.

13 When we have meat and such food before us, we get the impression: this is the dead body of a fish, this the dead body of a bird or a pig; and again, this fine Falernian wine is only a little grape juice, this purple robe just sheep's wool dyed with the blood of a shellfish. Such impressions reach the things themselves and penetrate them, so that we see what kind of things they really are. We should act this way all through life: where things seem most worthy of our approval, lay them bare, look at how worthless they are, and strip away the words that exalt them. For outward show is a wonderful corrupter of reason, and it cheats you most when you are most sure you are busy with things worth your trouble. Consider, then, what Crates says of Xenocrates himself.

14 Most of the things the crowd admires belong to the most general categories, things held together by mere cohesion or natural growth, such as stones, wood, fig trees, vines, olives. The things admired by men a little more reasonable are held together by a living principle, like flocks and herds. The things admired by men still better instructed are held together by a rational soul, though not a universal one, only a soul skilled in some craft or expert in some other way, or

simply rational in the sense of owning a number of slaves. But the man who values a rational soul, one that is universal and fitted for life in society, regards nothing else; above all he keeps his own soul in a state and activity in keeping with reason and social life, and he works toward this end together with others of his own kind.

15 Some things are hurrying into existence, others hurrying out of it; and of what is coming into being, part is already gone. Motions and changes are continually renewing the world, just as the unbroken passage of time is always renewing the infinite stretch of ages. In this flowing stream, where there is no firm footing, what is there among the things rushing by that anyone should prize highly? It would be like falling in love with one of the sparrows flying past, when it has already passed out of sight. Something like this is the very life of each of us, like the rising of vapor from the blood and the breathing of air. For just as it is to draw in the air once and give it back, which we do every moment, so it is with the whole power of breathing that you received at your birth, only yesterday or the day before, and give back to the element from which you first drew it.

16 Transpiration, as in plants, is nothing to be valued; nor is breathing, as in tame animals and wild beasts; nor receiving impressions through the appearances of things; nor being pulled about by desires like a puppet by strings; nor herding together; nor being nourished by food, which is just like getting rid of the useless part of what we eat. What, then, is worth valuing? To be applauded? No. Nor should we value the applause of tongues, for the praise of the many is just a clapping of tongues. So suppose you have given up this worthless thing called fame; what remains worth valuing?

This, in my opinion: to move yourself and to hold yourself back in keeping with your own constitution, the end to which all employments and arts lead. For every art aims at this, that the thing made should be fit for the work it was made for; and the vine grower tending his vine, the horse breaker, and the dog trainer all seek this end. And the education and teaching of the young aim at something too. Here, then, lies the value of education and teaching. And if this is sound, you will not seek anything else. Will you not stop valuing so many other things? Then you will be neither free, nor self-sufficient for your own happiness, nor free from passion. For you must of necessity be envious, jealous, and suspicious of those who can take those things away, and you will plot against those who have what you value. Anyone who wants any of these things must necessarily be in a state of inner turmoil, and besides, he must often find fault with the gods. But to reverence and honor your own mind will make you content with yourself, in harmony with society, and in agreement with the gods, that is, praising all that they give and have ordained.

17 Above, below, all around are the movements of the elements. But the motion of virtue is in none of these: it is something more divine, and advancing by a path scarcely noticed, it goes happily on its way.

18 How strangely people act! They will not praise those living at the same time and alongside them; yet to be praised themselves by future generations, by people they have never seen and never will see, they set great store. But this is much the same as being grieved that those who lived before you did not praise you.

19 If something is hard for you to accomplish, do not conclude that it is impossible for any human being; but if anything is possible for a human being and in keeping with his nature, consider that it is within your reach too.

20 Suppose in the wrestling ground a man has scratched you with his nails or struck your head and given you a bruise. We show no sign of being upset, take no offense, and do not afterward suspect him of foul play; yet we keep an eye on him, not as an enemy, nor with suspicion, but we quietly steer clear of him. Let your conduct be like this in all the other parts of life: let us overlook many things in those who are like our opponents in the ring. For it is in our power, as I said, to get out of the way and to hold no suspicion or hatred.

21 If anyone can convince me and show me that I am not thinking or acting rightly, I will gladly change; for I seek the truth, by which no one was ever harmed. But the one who is harmed is the one who persists in his own error and ignorance.

22 I do my duty: other things do not trouble me, for they are either things without life, or things without reason, or things that have wandered off and lost their way.

23 As for the animals that have no reason, and indeed all things and objects, since you have reason and they do not, make use of them in a generous and openhanded spirit. But toward human beings, since they have reason, behave in a spirit of fellowship. And on every occasion call on the gods; and do not worry about how long you will go on doing this, for even three hours so spent are enough.

24 Alexander of Macedon and his stable boy were brought by death to the same state; for either they were taken up

into the same generative principles of the universe, or they were alike scattered among the atoms.

25 Consider how many things take place in each of us in a single indivisible moment, things concerning the body and things concerning the soul; then you will not be surprised that far more, indeed all things that come into being, exist at the same time in that single whole which we call the Cosmos.

26 If someone put to you the question of how the name Antoninus is spelled, would you strain your voice as you uttered each letter? And if they grew angry, would you grow angry too? Would you not calmly go on and count out every letter? Just so in this life, remember that every duty is made up of certain parts. It is your duty to observe these, and without being disturbed or showing anger toward those who are angry with you, to go on your way and finish what is set before you.

27 How cruel it is not to let people pursue the things that seem to them suited to their nature and to their advantage! And yet, in a way, you do not allow them this when you are vexed because they do wrong. For they are surely drawn toward such things because they suppose them suited to their nature and to their advantage. But it is not so. Then teach them, and show them, without being angry.

28 Death is a cessation of impressions through the senses, of the tugging of the strings that move our appetites, of the ranging movements of our thoughts, and of our service to the flesh.

29 It is a shame for the soul to give way first in this life, while your body does not give way.

30 Take care that you are not turned into a Caesar, that you are not stained with that dye; for such things happen. Keep yourself simple, good, pure, serious, free of pretense, a friend of justice, a worshiper of the gods, kind, affectionate, and vigorous in all proper acts. Strive to remain such as philosophy wished to make you. Reverence the gods and help your fellow human beings. Life is short. The one fruit of this earthly life is a devout disposition and acts done for others. Do everything as a disciple of Antoninus. Remember his steadiness in every act done in keeping with reason, his evenness in all things, his piety, the serenity of his face, his sweetness, his disregard for empty fame, and his efforts to understand things; how he would never let anything pass without first examining it most carefully and understanding it clearly; how he bore with those who blamed him unjustly without blaming them back; how he did nothing in a hurry; how he refused to listen to slanders; how careful an examiner he was of characters and actions; how he was not given to reproaching people, nor timid, nor suspicious, nor a hairsplitter; how little contented him in lodging, bed, dress, food, and servants; how hardworking and patient he was; how, thanks to his sparing diet, he could hold out till evening, not even needing to relieve himself except at the usual hour; his firmness and constancy in his friendships; how he tolerated frank opposition to his opinions; the pleasure he took when anyone showed him something better; and how religious he was, without superstition. Imitate all this, so that when your last hour comes you may have as good a conscience as he had.

31 Return to your sober senses and call yourself back; and when you have roused yourself from sleep and realized

that it was only dreams that troubled you, then, awake again, look at the things around you as you looked at those dreams.

32 I am made up of a little body and a soul. To this little body all things are indifferent, for it cannot perceive differences. But to the understanding, only those things are indifferent that are not the work of its own activity; whatever is the work of its own activity is all within its power. And even of these, only those done with reference to the present, for as to the mind's future and past activities, even these are for the present indifferent.

33 Neither the labor done by the hand nor that done by the foot is contrary to nature, so long as the foot does the foot's work and the hand the hand's. So too a man's labor is not contrary to nature, as long as it does the things proper to a man. And if the labor is not contrary to his nature, neither is it an evil to him.

34 How many pleasures have been enjoyed by robbers, murderers of their own fathers, and tyrants.

35 Do you not see how craftsmen accommodate themselves up to a point to those unskilled in their trade, and yet hold fast to the principles of their art and will not bear to depart from them? Is it not strange, then, that the architect and the physician should have more respect for the principles of their own arts than a man has for his own reason, which he shares with the gods?

36 Asia and Europe are corners of the universe; the whole sea is a drop in the universe; Mount Athos a little clod of it; all present time a single point in eternity. All things are small, changeable, and perishable. All things come from that one universal ruling power, either directly or as

a consequence. And so the lion's gaping jaws, and poison, and every harmful thing, like a thorn or like mud, are by-products of what is grand and beautiful. Do not imagine, then, that they are of a different kind from what you revere, but form a just opinion of the source of all things.

37 Whoever has seen present things has seen everything, both all that has happened from eternity and all that will be through endless time; for all things are of one kind and one form.

38 Frequently consider how all things in the universe are connected and related to one another. For in a way all things are interwoven, and so all are friendly to one another; for one thing follows another in order, and this is by virtue of their active movement, their working together, and the unity of the substance.

39 Adapt yourself to the things your lot has cast you among; and the people among whom your portion has fallen, love them, but truly and sincerely.

40 Every instrument, tool, or vessel does well if it does what it was made for, and yet the one who made it is not present in it. But in things held together by nature, the power that made them is within and abides in them; and for this reason it is all the more fitting to reverence that power, and to consider that if you live and act according to its will, everything in you is in keeping with intelligence. And so too in the universe, the things that belong to it are in keeping with intelligence.

41 Whatever of the things not in your power you suppose to be good or evil for you, then necessarily, if such an evil befalls you or you lose such a good, you will blame the gods and hate other people too, those who caused the

misfortune or the loss, or those suspected of being likely to cause it; and indeed we do much wrong because we draw a distinction over these things. But if we judge only what is in our power to be good or bad, no reason remains either for finding fault with God or for taking a hostile stance toward any human being.

42 We are all working together toward one end, some knowingly and by design, others without knowing what they do, just as people do even while asleep, of whom it is Heraclitus, I think, who says that they too are workers and fellow contributors to what happens in the universe. But people cooperate in different ways: even those cooperate abundantly who find fault with what happens and try to oppose and hinder it, for the universe had need even of such men. It remains, then, for you to understand which kind of worker you place yourself among; for the one who governs all things will certainly make right use of you, and will receive you among some group of cooperators whose labors lead to one end. Only do not be such a part as the mean and ridiculous line in the play that Chrysippus speaks of.

43 Does the sun take on the work of the rain, or Asclepius the work of the earth that bears fruit? And what of each of the stars: are they not different, and yet do they not work together toward the same end?

44 If the gods have made decisions about me and about the things that must happen to me, they have decided well, for it is not easy even to imagine a deity without foresight; and as for harming me, why would they have any wish to do so? What advantage would come to them from this, or to the whole, which is the special object of their providence?

But if they have made no decision about me individually, they have certainly decided about the whole at least, and the things that happen as a consequence of this general arrangement I ought to accept gladly and be content with. But if they decide about nothing, which it is wicked to believe, and if we do believe it, then let us neither sacrifice, nor pray, nor swear by them, nor do anything else we do as though the gods were present and lived among us; but even if the gods decide about none of the things that concern us, I am able to decide about myself, and I can inquire into what is useful; and what is useful to each person is what is in keeping with his own constitution and nature. Now my nature is rational and social; and my city and country, insofar as I am Antoninus, is Rome, but insofar as I am a man, it is the world. The things that are useful to these cities, then, are the only things useful to me.

45 Whatever happens to anyone is for the good of the whole: this alone might be enough. But further you will observe this as a general truth, if you observe carefully, that whatever is profitable to one person is profitable to others too. But let the word profitable be taken here in the ordinary sense, as said of things of the middle kind, neither good nor bad.

46 Just as in the amphitheater and such places the constant sight of the same things and their sameness make the show tiresome, so it is with the whole of life; for all things, above and below, are the same and come from the same source. How long, then?

47 Think continually that all kinds of people, all kinds of pursuits, all sorts of nations are dead, so that your thoughts go right down even to Philistion, Phoebus, and Origanion.

Now turn your thoughts to the other kinds of men. To that place we too must move, where there are so many great orators, so many noble philosophers, Heraclitus, Pythagoras, Socrates; so many heroes of former days, and so many generals after them, and tyrants; and besides these, Eudoxus, Hipparchus, Archimedes, and other men of sharp natural talent, great minds, lovers of work, versatile, bold, even mockers of the perishable and fleeting life of man, like Menippus and those like him. Consider that all of these have long been in the dust. What harm is this to them, then; and what to those whose names are utterly unknown? One thing here is worth a great deal: to pass your life in truth and justice, with goodwill even toward liars and unjust men.

48 When you wish to give yourself joy, think of the virtues of those who live with you, for instance the energy of one, the modesty of another, the generosity of a third, and some other good quality of a fourth. For nothing gives such joy as the examples of the virtues, when they are displayed in the characters of those who live with us and present themselves to us as fully as possible. So we should keep them before our eyes.

49 You are not dissatisfied, I suppose, because you weigh only so many pounds and not three hundred. Then do not be dissatisfied that you must live only so many years and not more; for just as you are content with the amount of matter assigned to you, so be content with the amount of time.

50 Let us try to persuade people. But act even against their will when the principles of justice point that way. If, however, anyone uses force to stand in your way, turn to contentment and tranquillity, and at the same time use the

obstacle to exercise some other virtue; and remember that your attempt was made with a reservation, that you did not desire to do the impossible. What, then, did you desire? Just such an effort as this. And in that you succeed, even if the things you were aiming at are not accomplished.

51 The one who loves fame thinks another man's activity is his own good; the one who loves pleasure thinks his own sensations are; but the one who has understanding thinks his own acts are his own good.

52 It is in our power to hold no opinion about a thing and not to be disturbed in our soul; for things in themselves have no natural power to shape our judgments.

53 Train yourself to attend carefully to what another person says, and as far as possible to enter into the speaker's mind.

54 What is not good for the swarm is not good for the bee either.

55 If sailors abused the helmsman, or the sick abused the doctor, would they then listen to anyone else? Or how could the helmsman secure the safety of those in the ship, or the doctor the health of those he attends?

56 How many of those with whom I came into the world have already gone out of it.

57 To the jaundiced, honey tastes bitter; to those bitten by mad dogs, water brings terror; and to little children, a ball seems a fine thing. Why, then, am I angry? Do you think a false opinion has less power than the bile in the jaundiced man or the poison in the one bitten by a mad dog?

58 No one will keep you from living according to the reason of your own nature; nothing will happen to you contrary to the reason of universal nature.

59 What sort of people are those whom men wish to please, and for what ends, and by what kind of acts? How soon will time cover all things, and how many it has covered already.

VII

There is nothing new under the sun, he reminds himself, so judgments, not events, disturb us. He returns to the power of opinion, recovering composure, and keeping good humor amid the noise of human affairs.

1 What is wickedness? It is something you have seen many times before. With everything that happens, keep this in mind: it is something you have seen many times before. Up and down, everywhere, you will find the same things, the things that fill the old histories, the histories of past ages and of our own day, the things that fill cities and households now. There is nothing new. All of it is both familiar and short-lived.

2 How can your principles die, unless the thoughts that match them are snuffed out? But it is in your power to keep fanning these thoughts back into flame. I am able to hold whatever opinion I ought to hold about anything. If I am able, why am I troubled? The things outside my mind have no bearing on my mind at all. Once your feelings reach this state, you stand upright. To recover your life is in your

power. Look at things again the way you used to look at them, for in this lies the recovery of your life.

3 The pointless business of pageantry, plays on the stage, flocks of sheep, herds of cattle, sparring with spears, a bone tossed to puppies, a crumb of bread dropped into fishponds, the toil and load-hauling of ants, the scurrying of frightened little mice, puppets jerked on strings, all of it the same. It is your duty, then, in the midst of such things, to be good-humored and not put on airs, while understanding that every person is worth exactly as much as the things he busies himself with.

4 In conversation you must pay attention to what is being said, and in every action you must watch what is being done. In the one, look at once to the end it is aiming at; in the other, watch carefully for what is really meant.

5 Is my mind equal to this task or not? If it is equal to it, I use it for the work as an instrument given me by universal nature. But if it is not equal to it, then either I step back from the work and yield to someone better able to do it, unless there is some reason I ought not, or I do it as well as I can, calling in to help me the person who, with the guidance of my ruling mind, can do what is now fitting and useful for the common good. For whatever I do, whether by myself or with another, ought to be aimed at this alone: at what is useful and well suited to society.

6 How many who were celebrated by fame have been handed over to oblivion, and how many who celebrated the fame of others have themselves long been dead.

7 Do not be ashamed to be helped, for it is your business to do your duty like a soldier storming a town. So what if,

being lame, you cannot scale the battlements alone, but with another's help it can be done?

8 Do not let things to come trouble you, for you will meet them, if you must, carrying with you the same reason you now use for the things at hand.

9 All things are bound up with one another, and the bond is sacred; hardly anything is unconnected to anything else. For things have been arranged together, and they combine to make up one and the same universe. There is one universe made of all things, and one God who pervades all things, and one substance, and one law, one common reason in all intelligent creatures, and one truth, if indeed there is also one perfection for all creatures that share the same origin and partake of reason.

10 Everything material soon vanishes back into the substance of the whole; everything that gives form is very soon taken back into the universal reason; and the memory of everything is very soon swallowed up in time.

11 For the rational creature, the same act is both according to nature and according to reason.

12 Stand upright, or be set upright.

13 Just as it is with the parts of a single united body, so it is with rational beings, which exist separately yet have been made for one shared work. The awareness of this will become clearer to you if you often say to yourself: I am a limb of the body of rational beings. But if you say you are merely a part, you do not yet love your fellow human beings from the heart; doing good does not yet delight you for its own sake; you still do it merely as something proper, and not yet as doing good to yourself.

14 Let whatever will fall from outside fall upon the parts that can feel its impact. Those parts that have felt it may complain, if they choose. But I, unless I judge what has happened to be an evil, am not harmed. And it is in my power not to judge it so.

15 Whatever anyone does or says, I must be good, just as if the gold, or the emerald, or the purple were forever saying: whatever anyone does or says, I must be emerald and keep my color.

16 The ruling faculty does not disturb itself; I mean, it does not frighten itself or cause itself pain. But if anyone else can frighten or pain it, let him try. For the faculty itself will not, by its own opinion, turn itself toward such states. Let the body itself take care, if it can, that it suffers nothing, and let it speak up if it does suffer. But the soul itself, the part that is subject to fear and pain and has full power to form an opinion about these things, will suffer nothing, for it will never slide into such a judgment. The ruling principle in itself wants nothing, unless it creates a want for itself; and so it is free from disturbance and unobstructed, as long as it does not disturb and obstruct itself.

17 Happiness is a good spirit, or a good thing. So what are you doing here, imagination? Go away, I beg you by the gods, the same way you came, for I have no need of you. But you have come in your old habitual way. I am not angry with you; only go away.

18 Is anyone afraid of change? Why, what can happen at all without change? What is more pleasing or more natural to universal nature? Can you take a bath unless the wood undergoes change? Can you be nourished unless the food undergoes change? Can anything useful at all be accom-

plished without change? Do you not see, then, that for you to change is just the same thing, and equally necessary to universal nature?

19 Through the universal substance, as through a raging torrent, all bodies are swept along, united with the whole by their nature and working together with it, like the parts of our body with one another. How many a Chrysippus, how many a Socrates, how many an Epictetus has time already swallowed up! And let the same thought come to you about every person and every thing.

20 Only one thing troubles me: that I might do something the constitution of man does not allow, or in a way it does not allow, or that it does not allow now.

21 Near is your forgetting of all things, and near is your being forgotten by all.

22 It is peculiar to man to love even those who do wrong. This happens when it occurs to you, as they do wrong, that they are your kin, that they do wrong through ignorance and without meaning to, that soon you will both be dead, and above all that the wrongdoer has done you no harm, for he has not made your ruling faculty any worse than it was before.

23 Universal nature, out of the universal substance as if it were wax, now molds a horse, and when it has broken that up, uses the material for a tree, then for a man, then for something else; and each of these lasts only a very short time. But it is no hardship for the vessel to be broken up, just as there was none in its being put together.

24 A scowling look is entirely unnatural; when it is often put on, the result is that all comeliness dies away, and at last is so completely extinguished that it cannot be rekin-

dled at all. Try to draw from this very fact the conclusion that it is contrary to reason. For if even the awareness of doing wrong should leave you, what reason is there to go on living?

25 The nature that governs the whole will soon change everything you see, and out of their substance will make other things, and again other things out of the substance of those, so that the world may be forever new.

26 When someone has wronged you, consider at once what notion of good or evil led him to do wrong. For once you have seen this, you will pity him, and you will neither be amazed nor angry. For either you yourself hold the same thing to be good that he does, or something else of the same kind, in which case it is your duty to forgive him. But if you do not regard such things as good or evil, you will all the more readily be kindly toward someone who is in error.

27 Think not so much of what you do not have as of what you do have, and of the things you have, pick out the best, and then reflect how eagerly you would have hunted for them if you did not have them. At the same time, take care that you do not, by being so pleased with them, get into the habit of overvaluing them, so that you would be upset if you ever lost them.

28 Withdraw into yourself. The rational principle that rules has this nature: it is content with itself when it does what is just, and so secures its own tranquility.

29 Wipe out the imagination. Stop the pulling of the strings. Confine yourself to the present. Understand well what is happening, whether to you or to another. Divide and break down every object into its cause and its matter. Think

of your last hour. Let the wrong done by another stay there, where the wrong was done.

30 Direct your attention to what is being said. Let your understanding enter into the things being done and into the things doing them.

31 Adorn yourself with simplicity and modesty, and with indifference toward the things that lie between virtue and vice. Love humankind. Follow God. The poet says that law rules all, and it is enough to remember that law rules all.

32 About death: whether it is a scattering, or a dissolution into atoms, or annihilation, it is either an extinguishing or a change.

33 About pain: pain that is unbearable carries us off, but pain that lasts a long time is bearable; and the mind keeps its own tranquility by withdrawing into itself, and the ruling faculty is not made any worse. As for the parts that are harmed by pain, let them, if they can, speak their opinion about it.

34 About fame: look at the minds of those who chase it, observe what they are, and what sort of things they avoid, and what sort of things they pursue. And consider that, just as heaps of sand piled on one another bury the earlier sand, so in life the events that come before are soon buried by those that come after.

35 From Plato: Do you suppose it possible for a man with an elevated mind, who takes in the whole of time and the whole of substance, to think human life is anything great? It is not possible, he said. Then such a man will think that death too is no evil. Certainly not.

36 From Antisthenes: It is kingly to do good and to be abused for it.

37 It is a disgraceful thing for the face to be obedient, arranging and composing itself as the mind commands, while the mind does not arrange and compose itself.

38 It is no use being angry at events, for they care nothing about it.

39 To the immortal gods and to us give joy.

40 Life must be reaped like ripe ears of grain. One man is born; another dies.

41 Earth must be given back to earth; then life, for all, must be reaped like the harvest, as necessity commands.

42 If the gods care nothing for me and my children, there is a reason for it.

43 For the good is with me, and the just.

44 No joining others in their wailing, no violent passion.

45 From Plato: But I would give this man a sufficient answer, which is this. You speak wrongly if you think that a man worth anything at all ought to weigh the risk of life or death, and not rather look to this one thing in everything he does: whether he is doing what is just or unjust, the work of a good man or of a bad one.

46 For the truth is this, men of Athens: wherever a man has stationed himself, thinking it the best place for him, or has been stationed by his commander, there, in my opinion, he ought to stay and face the danger, reckoning nothing, neither death nor anything else, ahead of disgrace.

47 But, my good friend, consider whether what is noble and good is not something other than saving your life and being saved. As for a man's living a certain length of time, at least

if he is truly a man, consider whether this is not something to be put out of mind; there must be no clinging to life. A man must entrust these matters to the Deity and believe what the women say, that no one can escape his destiny, and the next question is how he may best live the time he has to live.

48 Look around at the courses of the stars, as if you were traveling along with them, and constantly consider how the elements change into one another, for such thoughts wash away the grime of life on earth.

49 This is a fine saying of Plato's: that whoever is discussing human beings should also look at earthly things as if viewing them from some higher place, looking at them in their gatherings, armies, farm labor, marriages, treaties, births, deaths, the uproar of the law courts, lonely places, the various tribes of barbarians, festivals, mournings, marketplaces, a mixture of all things and an orderly weaving together of opposites.

50 Consider the past, all those great shifts of political power; you can foresee the things to come as well. For they will certainly take the same form, and they cannot possibly stray from the pattern of what happens now. And so to have observed human life for forty years is the same as to have observed it for ten thousand. For what more will you see?

51 What has grown from the earth returns to the earth; but what has sprung from heavenly seed returns to the realms of heaven.

52 This is either a breaking apart of the atoms woven together, or a like scattering of the senseless elements.

53 With food and drink and cunning magic arts, turning the channel's course to escape death. The breeze that heaven has sent we must endure, and toil without complaint.

54 Another may be more skilled at throwing his opponent, but he is no more sociable, no more modest, no better trained to meet whatever happens, no more considerate of his neighbors' faults.

55 Wherever a work can be done in keeping with the reason common to gods and men, there we have nothing to fear; for where we can gain benefit through activity that succeeds and proceeds according to our constitution, there no harm is to be suspected.

56 Everywhere and always it is in your power to accept your present condition with reverence, to behave justly toward those around you, and to apply your skill to your present thoughts, so that nothing slips into them without being well examined.

57 Do not look around you to discover other people's ruling principles, but look straight to this: to what nature is leading you, both universal nature through the things that happen to you, and your own nature through the acts you must perform. Every being ought to do what accords with its constitution. All other things have been made for the sake of rational beings, just as among irrational things the lower exists for the sake of the higher; but rational beings exist for the sake of one another.

58 The chief principle, then, in man's constitution is the social one. The second is not to give in to the urgings of the body, for it is the special office of the rational and intelligent motion to set its own limits and never to be overpowered by the motion of the senses or of the appetites, since both of

these are animal; the intelligent motion claims supremacy and does not allow itself to be overpowered by the others. And rightly so, for it is formed by nature to make use of them all. The third thing in the rational constitution is freedom from error and from deception. Let the ruling principle, then, hold fast to these and go straight on, and it has what is its own.

59 Consider yourself dead, and that you have completed your life up to the present; and live the rest that is allowed you according to nature.

60 Love only what happens to you and is spun for you by the thread of your destiny. For what could suit you better?

61 In everything that happens, keep before your eyes those to whom the same things happened, and how they were vexed, and treated them as strange, and found fault with them. And now, where are they? Nowhere. Why, then, do you choose to act the same way? Why not leave these agitations, which are foreign to nature, to those who stir them up and those who are stirred by them? Why not be wholly intent on the right use of the things that happen to you? For then you will use them well, and they will be material for you to work on. Only attend to yourself, and resolve to be a good man in everything you do; and remember...

62 Look within. Within is the fountain of good, and it will keep bubbling up, if you will keep digging.

63 The body ought to be steady and to show no awkwardness in motion or posture. For what the mind shows in the face by keeping there an expression of intelligence and good order, that should be asked of the whole body as well. But all of this should be done without affectation.

64 The art of living is more like wrestling than dancing, in that it should stand ready and firm to meet whatever comes at it, sudden and unexpected.

65 Constantly observe who the people are whose approval you want, and what ruling principles they have. For then you will neither blame those who offend without meaning to, nor crave their approval, once you look to the sources of their opinions and desires.

66 Every soul, the philosopher says, is robbed of the truth against its will; and in the same way it is robbed of justice and self-control and kindness and everything of the sort. It is most necessary to keep this constantly in mind, for then you will be gentler toward everyone.

67 In every pain, let this thought be present: that there is no dishonor in it, and that it does not make the governing intelligence any worse, for it does no damage to the intelligence either as rational or as social. In most pains, too, let this remark of Epicurus help you: that pain is neither unbearable nor everlasting, if you keep in mind that it has its limits and add nothing to it in your imagination. And remember this as well, that many things which annoy us are really the same as pain, though we do not notice it, such as drowsiness, being scorched by heat, and having no appetite. So whenever you are discontented over any of these, say to yourself that you are giving in to pain.

68 Take care not to feel toward the inhuman the way they feel toward other people.

69 How do we know that Telauges was not finer in character than Socrates? It is not enough that Socrates died a more noble death, argued more skillfully with the sophists, endured a night in the cold with greater toughness, and that,

when ordered to arrest Leon of Salamis, judged it nobler to refuse, and that he walked the streets with a swagger, though one may well doubt whether that last point is even true. What we ought to ask is what sort of soul Socrates had, and whether he was able to be content with being just toward men and reverent toward the gods, neither pointlessly vexed at men's villainy, nor making himself a slave to any man's ignorance, nor treating anything that fell to his lot from the universe as strange, nor enduring it as unbearable, nor letting his understanding share in the feelings of the poor flesh.

70 Nature has not so blended the intelligence with the body's makeup as to deny you the power of setting your own limits and bringing under your control all that is your own; for it is quite possible to be a godlike man and to be recognized as such by no one. Always bear this in mind, and this too: that very little indeed is needed to live a happy life. And just because you have given up hope of becoming a logician and an expert in the knowledge of nature, do not for that reason give up the hope of being free and modest and social and obedient to God.

71 It is in your power to live free from all compulsion, in the greatest tranquility of mind, even if the whole world shouts against you all it likes, even if wild beasts tear apart the limbs of this lump of matter that has grown up around you. For what prevents the mind, in the midst of all this, from keeping itself in tranquility, in a just judgment of all that surrounds it, and in a ready use of whatever is set before it? So that the judgment may say to the thing it observes: This is what you are in reality, though in men's opinion you may seem to be something else. And the use may say to what-

ever comes to hand: You are the thing I was looking for; for to me whatever presents itself is always material for virtue, both rational and civic, and, in a word, for the practice of an art that belongs to man or God. For everything that happens is related either to God or to man, and is neither new nor hard to handle, but familiar and fit material to work on.

72 The perfection of character lies in this: in passing every day as if it were your last, neither violently agitated nor sluggish nor playing the hypocrite.

73 The gods, who are immortal, are not annoyed that for so long a time they must put up with men as they are, and so many of them bad; and besides this, they even take care of them in every way. But you, who are bound to die so soon, are you tired of putting up with the bad, and this when you are one of them?

74 It is absurd for a man not to flee from his own badness, which is in fact possible, but to flee from other men's badness, which is impossible.

75 Whatever the rational and social faculty finds to be neither intelligent nor social, it rightly judges to be beneath itself.

76 When you have done a good deed and another has been the better for it, why do you still go looking for some third thing besides, as fools do, either to get the reputation of having done a good deed or to be repaid?

77 No one tires of receiving what is useful. But acting according to nature is useful. So do not tire of receiving what is useful by doing it for others.

78 The nature of the All set itself in motion to make the universe. Now, either everything that happens follows

by way of consequence and connection, or else even the chief things toward which the ruling power of the universe directs its own movement are governed by no rational principle. If you remember this, it will make you more tranquil in many situations.

BOOK

VIII

He lets go of the wish to seem like a philosopher and aims only to live rightly with the time left. Reflections on judging your own acts, contentment, and acting for the common good.

1 This reflection also helps remove the craving for empty fame: it is no longer in your power to have lived your whole life, or even your life from youth onward, as a philosopher. It is plain, both to many others and to yourself, that you are far from being a philosopher. You have fallen into a confused way of living, so it is no longer easy for you to gain the reputation of a philosopher, and your manner of life works against it too. So if you have truly seen how matters stand, let go of the question of how you will appear to others, and be content to live the rest of your life as your nature wills. Notice, then, what it wills, and let nothing else distract you. You have wandered far and wide and found happiness nowhere: not in logical arguments, not in wealth, not in reputation, not in pleasure, nowhere. Where is it, then? In doing what human nature requires. And how does a person

do this? By holding to principles from which their feelings and actions flow. What principles? Those about good and bad: the belief that nothing is good for a person unless it makes them just, self-controlled, courageous, and free, and that nothing is bad unless it produces the opposite of these.

2 With every action you take, ask yourself: How does this affect me? Will I regret it? In a little while I will be dead and all of this will be gone. What more do I want, as long as what I am doing now is the work of an intelligent being, a social being, one who lives under the same law as God?

3 Alexander, Caesar, and Pompey, what are they compared to Diogenes, Heraclitus, and Socrates? Those philosophers understood the realities of things, their causes, their substance, and their guiding principles were aligned with their pursuits. But as for the others, how many things they had to worry about, and to how many things they were enslaved!

4 Bear in mind that people will go on doing the same things regardless, even if you burst with frustration.

5 This is the main thing: do not be disturbed, for all things happen according to the nature of the universe, and in a little while you will be no one and nowhere, just like Hadrian and Augustus. Next, fix your eyes steadily on the task before you, look at it, and at the same time remember that it is your duty to be a good person and to do what human nature demands, doing it without wavering; and say what seems to you most just, but say it with good will, with modesty, and without pretense.

6 The nature of the universe has this work to do: to move the things that are here to elsewhere, to change them, to take them away from here, and to carry them there. All things are change, yet we have no reason to fear anything

new. All things are familiar to us, and their distribution always stays the same.

7 Every nature is content with itself when it follows its proper course, and a rational nature follows its proper course when it gives its assent to nothing false or uncertain in its thoughts, when it directs its impulses only toward social action, when it limits its desires and aversions to things within its power, and when it is satisfied with everything assigned to it by the universal nature. For of this universal nature every particular nature is a part, just as the nature of a leaf is part of the nature of a plant; except that the leaf's nature is part of a nature that has no perception or reason and can be obstructed, while a human's nature is part of a nature that cannot be obstructed, that is intelligent and just, since it allots to everything its fair share according to its worth: its time, its substance, its cause, its activity, and its circumstances. But do not look to find any single thing equal in all respects to another single thing; rather, compare the whole of one thing, taken together, with the whole of another.

8 You do not have the leisure to read. But you do have the leisure to curb arrogance; you have the leisure to rise above pleasure and pain; you have the leisure to rise above the love of fame, and not to be annoyed by foolish and ungrateful people, but even to care for them.

9 Let no one ever again hear you complaining about life at court, or about your own life.

10 Regret is a kind of self-reproach for having neglected something useful; but what is good must also be useful, and the truly good person should attend to it. Yet no

such person would ever regret refusing a sensual pleasure. Therefore pleasure is neither good nor useful.

11 This thing, what is it in itself, in its own makeup? What is its substance and material? What is its causal nature? What is it doing in the world? And how long does it last?

12 When you rise from sleep reluctantly, remember that it is according to your makeup and to human nature to perform social acts, while sleeping is something you share even with irrational animals. And what is according to each individual's nature is more truly its own, more suited to it, and indeed more agreeable.

13 Constantly, and if possible at every impression that strikes your soul, apply to it the principles of physics, of ethics, and of logic.

14 Whatever person you meet, immediately say to yourself: What are this person's opinions about good and bad? For if they hold such and such views about pleasure and pain and their causes, about fame and disgrace, about death and life, then it will seem nothing surprising or strange to me when they act accordingly, and I will keep in mind that they are compelled to act this way.

15 Remember that just as it would be absurd to be surprised that a fig tree produces figs, so it is absurd to be surprised that the world produces the things it is bound to produce; and for a doctor and a ship's captain it would be a disgrace to be surprised that someone has a fever or that the wind is unfavorable.

16 Remember that changing your opinion and following someone who corrects your mistake is just as consistent with freedom as stubbornly persisting in your error. For the act is your own, carried out according to your own

impulse and judgment, and indeed according to your own understanding.

17 If something is within your own power, why do you do it? But if it is in another's power, whom do you blame, the atoms or the gods? Both are foolish. You must blame no one. For if you can, correct the cause; if you cannot do that, at least correct the thing itself; and if you cannot do even that, what good does it do you to find fault? Nothing should be done without purpose.

18 What has died does not fall out of the universe. If it remains here, it also changes here, and is dissolved into its proper parts, which are elements of the universe and of you. And these parts change too, and they do not complain.

19 Everything exists for some purpose: a horse, a vine. Why are you surprised? Even the sun will say, I exist for a purpose, and the rest of the gods will say the same. So what purpose do you exist for, to enjoy pleasure? See whether common sense allows this.

20 Nature has regard, in everything, no less for the ending than for the beginning and the continuance, just like a man throwing a ball into the air. What good is it for the ball to be thrown up, or what harm for it to come down, or even to have fallen? And what good is it to a bubble while it holds together, or what harm when it bursts? The same can be said of a flame.

21 Turn the body inside out and see what kind of thing it is; and what kind of thing it becomes when it has grown old, and when it is diseased.

22 Short-lived are both the one who praises and the one praised, the one who remembers and the one remembered, and all of this in a small corner of this part of the world; and

even here people do not all agree, no, not even one person with themselves; and the whole earth too is but a point.

23 Attend to the matter before you, whether it is an opinion, an action, or a word.

24 You suffer this justly, because you would rather become good tomorrow than be good today.

25 Am I doing something? I do it for the good of mankind. Does something happen to me? I accept it and refer it to the gods and to the source of all things, from which everything that happens flows.

26 Just as bathing appears to you as oil, sweat, dirt, filthy water, all of it disgusting, so is every part of life and everything in it.

27 Lucilla saw Verus die, and then Lucilla died. Secunda saw Maximus die, and then Secunda died. Epitynchanus saw Diotimus die, and then Epitynchanus died. Antoninus saw Faustina die, and then Antoninus died. So it is with everything. Celer saw Hadrian die, and then Celer died. And those sharp-witted people, whether prophets or men puffed up with pride, where are they now? For instance the sharp-witted Charax, Demetrius the Platonist, Eudaemon, and anyone else like them? All short-lived, dead long ago. Some were not remembered even briefly; others have become the heroes of legends; and still others have vanished even from the legends. Remember, then, that this little composite thing, yourself, must either be dissolved, or your poor breath must be snuffed out, or be moved and placed elsewhere.

28 It is a satisfaction to a person to do the proper work of a human being. Now the proper work of a human being is to be kind to one's own kind, to disdain the urges of the senses,

to form a sound judgment of plausible appearances, and to take a survey of the nature of the universe and of the things that happen in it.

29 There are three relationships: the first to the body that surrounds you; the second to the divine cause from which all things come to all; and the third to the people who live alongside you.

30 Pain is either an evil to the body, in which case let the body say what it thinks of it, or an evil to the soul; but it is in the soul's power to keep its own serenity and calm, and not to think pain an evil. For every judgment, impulse, desire, and aversion is within, and no evil rises that high.

31 Wipe out your imaginings by often saying to yourself: Right now it is in my power to let no wickedness be in this soul, nor desire, nor any disturbance at all; but looking at all things I see what their nature is, and I use each according to its value. Remember this power that nature has given you.

32 Speak in the senate and to every person, whoever they may be, appropriately and without affectation; use plain speech.

33 Augustus' court, his wife, daughter, descendants, ancestors, sister, Agrippa, his relatives, his close companions, his friends; Areius, Maecenas, his physicians, his sacrificing priests, the whole court is dead. Then turn to the rest, considering not the death of a single person but of a whole line, like the Pompeys; and that inscription on the tombs, The last of his line. Then consider what trouble those before them went through so as to leave a successor; and then that, of necessity, someone must be the last. Here again, consider the death of an entire line.

34 It is your duty to order your life well in every single act; and if every act does its duty as far as possible, be content; and no one can prevent each act from doing its duty. But some external thing will get in the way. Nothing will get in the way of your acting justly, soberly, and thoughtfully. But perhaps some other capacity for action will be hindered. Well then, by accepting the hindrance and being content to redirect your efforts to what is permitted, another opportunity for action is immediately set before you in place of the one that was blocked, one that fits the very ordering of life we are speaking of.

35 Receive wealth or prosperity without arrogance, and be ready to let it go.

36 If you ever saw a hand cut off, or a foot, or a head, lying somewhere apart from the rest of the body, that is what a person makes of themselves, as far as they can, who is not content with what happens, who cuts themselves off from others, or who does anything unsocial. Suppose you have detached yourself from the natural unity, for by nature you were made a part, but now you have cut yourself off; yet here is a beautiful provision: it is in your power to unite yourself again. God has granted this to no other part, that after being severed and cut off it may come together again. But consider the kindness with which he has honored humanity, for he has given a person the power not to be severed from the whole at all, and, once severed, to return, to be reunited, and to resume their place as a part.

37 Just as the nature of the universe has given every rational being all the other powers it has, so we have received this power from it too. For just as the universal nature turns and fixes in its appointed place everything that stands in

its way and opposes it, making such things a part of itself, so too the rational being is able to turn every obstacle into material of its own and use it for whatever purposes it has in mind.

38 Do not disturb yourself by thinking of your whole life. Do not let your thoughts take in all at once the various troubles you may expect to befall you; instead, on each occasion ask yourself: What is there in this present thing that is unbearable and beyond enduring? You will be ashamed to admit there is anything. Next, remember that neither the future nor the past weighs on you, but only the present. And this shrinks to very little if you isolate it by itself, and rebuke your mind if it cannot hold out against even this.

39 Does Panthea or Pergamus now sit by the tomb of Verus? Does Chabrias or Diotimus sit by the tomb of Hadrian? That would be ridiculous. And even if they did sit there, would the dead be aware of it? And if the dead were aware, would they be pleased? And if they were pleased, would that make them immortal? Was it not in the order of destiny that these people too should first become old women and old men, and then die? And what would they do once these mourners were dead? All of this is foul-smelling stuff and blood in a bag.

40 If you can see clearly, look and judge wisely, says the philosopher.

41 In the makeup of the rational being I see no virtue that opposes justice; but I do see a virtue that opposes the love of pleasure, and that is self-control.

42 If you take away your opinion about what seems to give you pain, you yourself stand in perfect safety. Who is this self? The reason. But I am not just reason. Very well. Then

let the reason not trouble itself. And if any other part of you suffers, let it hold its own opinion about itself.

43 Obstruction to the perceptions of the senses is an evil to the animal nature. Obstruction to its impulses is equally an evil to the animal nature. And something else likewise is an obstruction and an evil to the makeup of plants. So in the same way, whatever obstructs the intelligence is an evil to the intelligent nature. Now apply all of this to yourself. Does pain or sensual pleasure affect you? The senses will deal with that. Has some obstacle blocked you in your efforts toward a goal? If you were pursuing that goal unconditionally, with no reservation, then yes, this obstacle is an evil to you considered as a rational being. But if you take into account the usual course of things, you have not yet been harmed, or even hindered. As for the things that properly belong to the understanding, no other person is able to hinder them, for neither fire, nor iron, nor a tyrant, nor abuse can touch it in any way. Once it has been made a sphere, it remains a sphere.

44 It is not right that I should give myself pain, for I have never intentionally given pain even to another.

45 Different things delight different people; but my delight is to keep my ruling faculty sound, turning away from no person and from none of the things that happen to people, but looking at all of them and receiving them with welcoming eyes, and using everything according to its value.

46 See that you secure this present time for yourself, for those who chase fame after death do not consider that the people of later times will be exactly like these whom they cannot stand now, and both are mortal. And what is it to

you, in any case, if these people of later times utter this or that sound, or hold this or that opinion about you?

47 Take me and cast me wherever you wish; for there too I will keep my divine part tranquil, that is, content, as long as it can feel and act in keeping with its proper makeup. Is this change of place a good enough reason for my soul to become unhappy and worse than it was, downcast, overstretched, shrinking, terrified? What could you find that would be a good enough reason for that?

48 Nothing can happen to a person that is not a human experience, nor to an ox that is not in keeping with the nature of an ox, nor to a vine that is not in keeping with the nature of a vine, nor to a stone that is not proper to a stone. So if what happens to each thing is both usual and natural, why should you complain? For the common nature brings nothing you cannot bear.

49 If you are pained by some external thing, it is not that thing that disturbs you, but your own judgment about it. And it is in your power to wipe out this judgment right now. But if something in your own disposition gives you pain, who prevents you from correcting your view? And even if you are pained because you are not doing something that seems right to you, why not act instead of complaining? But some insurmountable obstacle is in the way. Then do not be distressed, for the cause of its not being done lies not with you. But it is not worth living if I cannot do this. Then depart from life contentedly, just as one dies who is in full activity, and at peace even with the things that obstruct them.

50 Remember that the ruling faculty is invincible when, gathered within itself, it is satisfied with itself, doing nothing it does not choose to do, even if its resistance comes

from mere stubbornness. What, then, will it be like when it forms a judgment about something with the aid of reason and deliberation? For this reason a mind free from passions is a fortress, for a person has nothing more secure to flee to for refuge and to be forever unassailable. Whoever has not seen this is ignorant; but whoever has seen it and does not flee to this refuge is wretched.

51 Say nothing more to yourself than what the first appearances report. Suppose it is reported to you that a certain person speaks ill of you. That has been reported; but that you have been harmed, that has not been reported. I see that my child is sick. I do see that; but that he is in danger, I do not see. So always stay with the first appearances, and add nothing of your own from within, and then nothing happens to you. Or rather, add something, like a person who knows everything that happens in the world.

52 A cucumber is bitter? Throw it away. There are briars in the road? Turn aside from them. That is enough. Do not add, And why were such things made in the world? For you would be laughed at by someone who understands nature, just as you would be laughed at by a carpenter or a shoemaker if you found fault with the shavings and offcuts you see in their workshop. And yet they have places to throw their shavings and offcuts, while the universal nature has no space outside herself; but the marvel of her art is that, though she has enclosed herself within limits, she changes into herself everything within her that seems to decay, grow old, and become useless, and from these very same things she makes other new things, so that she needs no material from outside and requires no place to dump what decays.

She is content, then, with her own space, her own matter, and her own art.

53 Do not be sluggish in your actions, nor disorderly in your conversation, nor scattered in your thoughts; let there be no inner conflict in your soul, nor any outward gushing of it, and do not be so busy in life that you have no leisure.

54 Suppose people kill you, cut you to pieces, curse you. What can these things do to keep your mind from remaining pure, wise, sober, and just? For instance, if someone stood beside a clear, pure spring and cursed it, the spring would never stop sending up drinkable water; and if he threw clay or filth into it, it would quickly scatter and wash them away, and would not be polluted at all. How, then, will you possess a perpetual fountain, and not a mere well? By shaping yourself, hour by hour, toward freedom joined with contentment, simplicity, and modesty.

55 Whoever does not know what the world is does not know where they are. And whoever does not know the purpose for which the world exists does not know who they are, nor what the world is. But whoever has failed to grasp any one of these could not even say for what purpose they themselves exist. What, then, do you make of someone who chases the praise of those who applaud, of people who know neither where they are nor who they are?

56 Do you wish to be praised by someone who curses himself three times an hour? Would you wish to please someone who does not please himself? Does a person please himself who regrets nearly everything he does?

57 No longer let your breathing alone be in concert with the air that surrounds you; let your intelligence too now be in harmony with the intelligence that embraces all things. For

the intelligent power is no less diffused through all parts and pervading all things, for the one who is willing to draw it in, than the power of the air is for the one who is able to breathe it.

58 In general, wickedness does no harm at all to the universe; and in particular, one person's wickedness does no harm to another. It is only harmful to the one who possesses it, who has it in their own power to be free of it the moment they choose.

59 To my own free will, my neighbor's free will is just as indifferent as their poor breath and flesh. For though we are made above all for one another's sake, still the ruling power of each of us has its own province; otherwise my neighbor's wickedness would be my harm, which God has not willed, so that my unhappiness need not depend on another.

60 The sun seems to be poured down and is indeed diffused in all directions, yet it is not poured away. For this diffusion is an extension; that is why its beams are called extensions, because they are extended. You can judge what kind of thing a ray is by looking at the sun's light passing through a narrow opening into a darkened room, for it is extended in a straight line, and is, as it were, divided when it meets any solid body that stands in its way and blocks the air beyond; yet there the light remains fixed and does not slide off or fall away. Such, then, should be the outpouring and diffusion of the understanding: in no way a pouring away, but an extension, making no violent or forceful collision with the obstacles in its path, and not falling down, but staying fixed and illuminating whatever receives it. For a body deprives itself of the light if it does not let it in.

61 Whoever fears death fears either the loss of sensation or a different kind of sensation. But if you will have no sensation, then you will feel no harm; and if you will acquire a different kind of sensation, you will be a different kind of living being and will not cease to live.

62 People exist for the sake of one another. So either teach them, or put up with them.

63 An arrow moves in one way, the mind in another. The mind, even when it exercises caution and when it is engaged in inquiry, moves no less straight ahead, toward its goal.

64 Enter into every person's ruling faculty, and also let every other person enter into yours.

BOOK

IX

Centers on justice and truth as obligations we owe one another, since we were made to cooperate. To lie, to be unjust, or to chase pleasure as the only good is to fight against nature itself.

1 Whoever acts unjustly acts irreverently toward the divine. Since universal nature made rational beings for one another's sake, to help each other as each deserves and never to harm one another, anyone who breaks her will is plainly guilty of irreverence toward the highest divinity. The liar, too, is guilty of irreverence toward that same divinity, for universal nature is the nature of all things that exist, and existing things are related to everything that comes into being. Furthermore, this universal nature is named truth, and is the first cause of all things that are true. So the man who lies on purpose is guilty of irreverence, since by deceiving he acts unjustly; and the man who lies without meaning to is also guilty, since he is out of step with universal nature and disturbs the order of things by fighting against the world's nature. For he does fight against it who,

of his own accord, moves toward what is contrary to truth, since he had received from nature the powers which, by neglecting them, he can no longer use to tell falsehood from truth. And the man who chases pleasure as good and runs from pain as evil is likewise guilty of irreverence. For such a man must constantly find fault with universal nature, complaining that it hands out things to the bad and the good unfairly, because the bad so often enjoy pleasure and own the things that produce it, while the good get pain as their lot and the things that cause it. Again, the man who is afraid of pain will sometimes also be afraid of things that are bound to happen in the world, and that itself is irreverence. And the man who chases pleasure will not hold back from injustice, and that is plainly irreverence. Now toward those things to which universal nature is equally disposed—for it would not have made both unless it were equally disposed toward both—those who wish to follow nature should be of the same mind and equally disposed. So with regard to pain and pleasure, death and life, honor and dishonor, all of which universal nature uses equally, whoever is not equally disposed is clearly acting irreverently. And when I say universal nature uses them equally, I mean that they happen alike to those produced in continuous succession and to those who come after them, by virtue of a certain original movement of Providence, by which it moved from a certain beginning toward this ordering of things, having conceived certain principles of the things that were to be, and having determined the powers that produce beings and changes and such successions.

2 It would be a man's happiest fate to leave the human race without ever having tasted lying and hypocrisy and excess

and pride. But to breathe out one's life when one has had quite enough of these things is, as the saying goes, the next best voyage. Have you decided to stay on with vice? Has experience not yet persuaded you to flee this plague? For the ruin of the understanding is a plague—far more so, in fact, than any corruption or change in the air around us. That corruption is a plague to animals insofar as they are animals; but this other one is a plague to human beings insofar as they are human.

3 Do not look down on death, but welcome it gladly, since it too is one of the things nature wills. For just as it is natural to be young and to grow old, to develop and reach maturity, to grow teeth and a beard and gray hair, to father children, to conceive, to give birth, and to go through all the other natural processes the seasons of your life bring, so too is dying. This, then, befits a thoughtful person: to be neither careless nor impatient nor scornful about death, but to wait for it as one of nature's operations. Just as you now wait for the time when the child will come out of your wife's womb, so be ready for the time when your soul will drop out of this shell. But if you also want a more ordinary kind of comfort, something to touch your heart, you will be best reconciled to death by looking at the things you are about to leave behind and the characters of the people your soul will no longer be mixed up with. For it is in no way right to be angry with people; instead, it is your duty to care for them and bear with them gently. And yet remember that you will not be departing from people who share your principles. For this is the only thing, if anything, that could pull us the other way and keep us attached to life—the chance to live among people who share our principles. But as it is, you see

how much trouble comes from the discord of those who live together, so that you may well say: Come quickly, death, lest I too forget myself.

4 Whoever does wrong does wrong to himself. Whoever acts unjustly acts unjustly to himself, because he makes himself bad.

5 A man often acts unjustly by not doing something, not only by doing something.

6 Your present judgment, grounded in understanding; your present conduct, directed toward the common good; your present attitude, content with everything that happens—that is enough.

7 Wipe out your impressions; rein in your desires; put out your appetites; keep the ruling faculty under its own control.

8 Among animals that have no reason, a single life is distributed; but among rational animals, a single intelligent soul is distributed—just as there is a single earth for all things of an earthly nature, and we all see by one light and breathe one air, all of us who have the power of sight and all who have life.

9 All things that share in something common to them move toward what is of their own kind. Everything earthy turns toward the earth; everything liquid flows together; everything of an airy kind does the same—so that they have to be kept apart by something, by the application of force. Fire, it is true, moves upward because of the elemental fire, yet it is so ready to catch with any fire here that even any fairly dry substance is easily set alight, because there is less mixed into it of what resists burning. In the same way, then, everything that shares in the common intelligent nature

moves toward what is of its own kind—indeed moves even more strongly. For the more it surpasses all other things, the more ready it is to mingle with and fuse into what is akin to it. So among animals without reason we find swarms of bees, herds of cattle, the rearing of young birds, and, in a way, loves—for even in animals there are souls, and the power that draws them together is seen to assert itself to a higher degree than is ever observed in plants or stones or trees. But in rational animals there are political communities, friendships, families, and gatherings; and in wars, treaties and truces. And in things still higher, even though they are separated from one another, a kind of unity exists, as among the stars. Thus the ascent to a higher degree can produce sympathy even in things that are separated. See, then, what is happening now: only intelligent animals have forgotten this mutual longing and attraction, and in them alone the tendency to flow together is not seen. But still, though people try to avoid this union, they are caught and held by it, for their nature is too strong for them; and you will see what I mean if you simply observe. You will sooner find something earthy that touches no other earthy thing than a person wholly cut off from other people.

10 Both man and God and the universe bear fruit; each does so in its proper season. And if common usage has fixed the word ‘fruit’ especially to the vine and such things, that is nothing. Reason bears fruit both for all and for itself, and from it come other things of the same kind as reason itself.

11 If you can, correct those who do wrong by teaching them; but if you cannot, remember that forbearance was given to you for this very purpose. The gods, too, are forbearing toward such people; for certain ends they even help them

obtain health, wealth, and reputation—that is how kind they are. And this is in your power as well; or tell me, who is stopping you?

12 Do your work not like someone miserable, nor like someone who wants to be pitied or admired; aim your will at one thing only—to set yourself in motion and to check yourself, as social reason requires.

13 Today I have escaped all trouble—or rather, I have thrown out all trouble, for it was not outside me but within, in my own judgments.

14 All things are the same: familiar from experience, short-lived in time, and worthless in substance. Everything now is exactly as it was in the days of those we have buried.

15 Things stand outside of us, by themselves and on their own, knowing nothing of themselves and passing no judgment. What is it, then, that judges about them? The ruling faculty.

16 For the rational social animal, evil and good lie not in being acted upon but in acting, just as his virtue and his vice lie not in being acted upon but in acting.

17 For the stone that has been thrown up, it is no evil to come down, nor was it any good to have been carried up.

18 Look inside men's guiding principles, and you will see what kind of judges you are afraid of, and what kind of judges they are of themselves.

19 All things are changing, and you yourself are in constant change and, in a way, in constant destruction—and so is the whole universe.

20 It is your duty to leave another man's wrongdoing right where it is.

21 The ending of an activity, the cessation of a movement or an opinion—their death, in a sense—is no evil. Turn your thoughts now to your own life: your life as a child, as a youth, as a grown man, in old age; for in each of these every change was a death. Was this anything to fear? Turn your thoughts now to your life under your grandfather, then your life under your mother, then your life under your father; and as you find many other differences and changes and endings, ask yourself: Is this anything to fear? In the same way, then, neither is the ending and cessation and change of your whole life anything to be afraid of.

22 Be quick to examine your own ruling faculty, and that of the universe, and that of your neighbor: your own, so that you may make it just; that of the universe, so that you may remember what you are a part of; and that of your neighbor, so that you may know whether he acted in ignorance or with knowledge, and may also consider that his ruling faculty is akin to your own.

23 Just as you yourself are a part of a social system, so let every act of yours be a part of social life. Any act of yours, then, that has no reference, directly or indirectly, to a social end tears your life apart, does not let it be one, and is of the nature of mutiny—just as, in a public assembly, a man who acts on his own stands apart from the general agreement.

24 The squabbles and games of little children, and feeble spirits carrying corpses about—such is everything; so that what is shown in the picture of the underworld strikes the eye more sharply.

25 Examine the quality of an object's form, separate it entirely from its material part, and then contemplate it; then

work out the longest time that a thing of this particular form is naturally made to last.

26 You have endured endless troubles by not being content with your ruling faculty when it does the things it was constituted by nature to do. But enough of this.

27 When someone blames you or hates you, or when people say anything hurtful about you, go to their poor souls, get inside, and see what kind of men they are. You will discover that there is no reason to trouble yourself about what opinion they have of you. Even so, you must be well disposed toward them, for by nature they are friends. And the gods, too, help them in every way—by dreams, by signs—toward attaining the things they value.

28 The periodic movements of the universe are the same, up and down, from age to age. Either the universal intelligence sets itself in motion for each separate effect—and if so, be content with what results from its activity; or it set itself in motion once, and everything else follows as a kind of consequence; or indivisible elements are the origin of all things. In short, if there is a god, all is well; and if chance rules, do not you too be ruled by it.

29 Soon the earth will cover us all; then the earth itself will change, and the things that result from that change will go on changing forever, and these again forever. For if a man reflects on these changes and transformations, following one another like wave after wave, and on how fast they come, he will look down on everything that perishes.

30 The universal cause is like a winter torrent: it sweeps everything along with it. But how worthless are all these poor people busy with political affairs and, as they imagine, playing the philosopher—all of them drivellers. Well then,

man: do what nature now requires. Set yourself in motion, if it is in your power, and do not look around to see whether anyone notices; and do not wait for Plato's Republic, but be content if the smallest thing goes well, and consider such an outcome no small matter. For who can change men's opinions? And without a change of opinions, what is there but the slavery of men who groan while pretending to obey? Come now, tell me of Alexander and Philip and Demetrius of Phalerum. They themselves shall judge whether they found out what the common nature required and trained themselves accordingly. But if they acted like heroes in a tragedy, no one has condemned me to imitate them. The work of philosophy is simple and modest. Do not pull me aside into insolence and pride.

31 Look down from above on the countless herds of men, their countless ceremonies, their endlessly varied voyages through storms and calms, and the differences among those who are born, live together, and die. Consider, too, the lives lived by others long ago, the lives of those who will live after you, and the lives now lived among foreign nations; how many do not even know your name, and how many will soon forget it; how those who perhaps praise you now will very soon blame you; and that neither a name after death, nor reputation, nor anything else is of any value.

32 Let there be freedom from disturbance regarding the things that come from external causes; and let there be justice in the things done by your own internal cause—that is, let your movement and action end in this, in social acts, for this is in keeping with your nature.

33 You can clear away many of the useless things that disturb you, for they lie entirely in your own opinion; and

you will then gain ample room for yourself by taking in the whole universe with your mind, contemplating the eternity of time, and observing how rapidly each separate thing changes—how short the span is from birth to dissolution, and how limitless the time before birth, and equally boundless the time after dissolution.

34 All that you see will quickly perish, and those who watched it dissolve will very soon perish too. And the man who dies at the most extreme old age will be brought to the same condition as the one who died too soon.

35 What are these men's guiding principles? With what kinds of things do they busy themselves? For what kinds of reasons do they love and honor? Imagine you can see their poor souls laid bare. When they suppose they do harm by blaming you or good by praising you, what a delusion!

36 Loss is nothing other than change. But universal nature delights in change, and in obedience to her all things are now done well, have been done so from eternity in the same form, and will be so for time without end. What, then, are you saying—that all things have been and always will be bad, and that no power was ever found among so many gods to set these things right, but that the world has been condemned to be bound in unceasing evil?

37 The rottenness of the matter that underlies everything! Water, dust, bones, filth; or again, marble—the calluses of the earth; gold and silver—mere sediment; clothing—just bits of hair; purple dye—just blood; and everything else is of the same kind. Even what is of the nature of breath is another thing of the same kind, changing from this to that.

38 Enough of this wretched life, and grumbling, and aping tricks. Why are you disturbed? What is there new in this?

What unsettles you? Is it the form of the thing? Look at it. Or is it the matter? Look at it. Beyond these there is nothing. So, toward the gods, become at last simpler and better. It makes no difference whether you examine these things for a hundred years or for three.

39 If a man has done wrong, the harm is his own. But perhaps he has not done wrong.

40 Either all things come from one intelligent source and fit together as in a single body—and then the part ought not to find fault with what is done for the good of the whole; or there are only atoms, and nothing but mixture and dispersion. Why, then, are you disturbed? Say to your ruling faculty: Are you dead? Are you corrupted? Are you playing the hypocrite? Have you become a beast? Do you herd and feed with the rest?

41 Either the gods have no power, or they have power. If they have no power, why do you pray to them? But if they have power, why not pray that they grant you the ability not to fear any of the things you fear, not to desire any of the things you desire, and not to grieve over anything—rather than praying that some of these things should or should not happen? For surely, if they can cooperate with men at all, they can cooperate toward these ends. But perhaps you will say: the gods have put these things in my own power. Well, then, is it not better to use what is in your power like a free man than to crave, in a slavish and groveling way, what is not in your power? And who told you that the gods do not help us even in the things that are in our power? Just start praying for such things, and you will see. One man prays: How may I manage to sleep with that woman? You pray: How may I not desire to sleep with her? Another prays: How

may I be rid of this? You pray: How may I not desire to be rid of it? Another: How may I not lose my little son? You: How may I not be afraid to lose him? In short, turn your prayers this way, and see what comes of it.

42 Epicurus says: In my illness, my conversation was not about my bodily sufferings, nor, he says, did I talk of such things to those who visited me; instead I went on discussing the nature of things as before, keeping to this main point—how the mind, while sharing in such disturbances as go on in the poor flesh, can stay free of upheaval and keep hold of its own proper good. Nor, he says, did I give the doctors the chance to put on solemn looks, as if they were doing something great; my life went on well and happily. Do the same, then, that he did, both in sickness, if you fall sick, and in any other circumstance. For never to abandon philosophy whatever happens to us, and not to chatter idly with an ignorant man or one who knows nothing of nature, is a principle of all schools of philosophy; and so is being intent only on what you are doing now and on the instrument with which you do it.

43 When you are offended by someone's shameless behavior, ask yourself at once: Is it possible, then, for shameless men not to exist in the world? It is not possible. So do not demand the impossible. This man is simply one of those shameless men who must necessarily exist in the world. Keep the same considerations in mind in the case of the cheat, the faithless man, and everyone who does wrong in any way. For the moment you remind yourself that it is impossible for such men not to exist, you will be more kindly disposed toward each of them as an individual. It is useful, too, to notice right away, when the occasion arises,

what virtue nature has given man to set against each kind of wrongdoing. As an antidote to the obtuse man she has given mildness, and against another kind of man some other power. And in every case it is possible for you to correct, by teaching, the man who has gone astray; for every man who errs misses his aim and has gone astray. Besides, how have you been harmed? You will find that none of those you are irritated with has done anything to make your mind worse; and what is bad and harmful to you has its foundation only in your mind. And what harm is done, or what is strange about it, if a man who has not been taught does the things of an untaught man? Consider whether you should not rather blame yourself for not expecting such a man to err in such a way. Your reason gave you the means to suppose he would likely make this mistake, and yet you forgot, and now you are amazed that he has erred. But most of all, when you blame a man as faithless or ungrateful, turn to yourself. For the fault is plainly your own—whether you trusted that a man with such a disposition would keep his promise, or whether, in doing him a kindness, you did not do it unconditionally, nor in such a way as to have received the whole profit from the very act. For what more do you want, when you have done a man a service? Is it not enough that you have done something in keeping with your nature—must you seek to be paid for it? That would be as if the eye demanded a reward for seeing, or the feet for walking. For just as these members were made for a particular purpose, and by working according to their own constitution get what is their own, so too man, formed by nature for acts of kindness, when he has done something kind or otherwise serving the common interest, has acted in keeping with his constitution and gets what is his own.

B O O K

X

An intimate appeal to his own soul to become simple, content, and free of craving. He works on accepting his lot from the gods and looking honestly at people and things as they really are.

1 Will you ever, my soul, be good and simple and single and bare, more visible than the body that surrounds you? Will you ever taste a loving and contented disposition? Will you ever be full and lacking nothing, longing for nothing more, craving nothing—neither living thing nor object—for the enjoyment of pleasures? Will you stop craving more time in which to enjoy them longer, or a particular place, or a pleasant climate, or the company of people you can live with in harmony? Instead, will you be satisfied with your present condition, pleased with everything around you, and convince yourself that you have everything you need, that it all comes from the gods, that everything is well for you and will be well whatever they choose to give for the preservation of that perfect living being—the good and just and beautiful—which generates and holds all things together,

and contains and embraces all things that dissolve so that other like things can be produced? Will you ever be such that you can live in community with gods and with people, never finding fault with them and never being condemned by them?

2 Observe what your nature requires insofar as you are governed by nature alone; then do it and accept it, provided your nature as a living being is not made worse by it. Next, observe what your nature requires insofar as you are a living being, and allow yourself all of that, provided your nature as a rational creature is not made worse by it. But a rational creature is by consequence also a social creature. So use these rules, and trouble yourself about nothing else.

3 Everything that happens either happens in a way you are naturally formed to bear, or in a way you are not. If it happens in a way you are formed to bear, do not complain, but bear it as you are formed to bear it. But if it happens in a way you are not formed to bear, still do not complain, for it will perish after it has consumed you. Remember, though, that you are naturally formed to bear everything that your own judgment can make enduring and tolerable, by thinking that it is either in your interest or your duty to do so.

4 If someone is mistaken, instruct him kindly and show him his error. But if you cannot, blame yourself—or not even yourself.

5 Whatever happens to you was prepared for you from all eternity; the chain of causes was, from eternity, spinning the thread of your existence and of everything that befalls it.

6 Whether the universe is a chance gathering of atoms, or a system governed by nature, let this first be settled: that I

am a part of the whole which nature governs; and next, that I am in some way intimately related to the other parts of the same kind as myself. Remembering this, then, as a part I will be discontented with none of the things assigned to me out of the whole; for nothing that benefits the whole is harmful to the part. The whole contains nothing that is not for its own advantage. All natures share this principle, but the nature of the universe has this besides: that no external cause can ever compel it to generate anything harmful to itself. Remembering, then, that I am a part of such a whole, I will be content with everything that happens. And since I am intimately related to the parts of the same kind as myself, I will do nothing unsocial, but rather direct myself toward those who are akin to me, turn all my efforts toward the common good, and turn them away from the opposite. If things are done this way, life must flow on happily—just as you would expect the life of a citizen to be happy who pursues a course of action that benefits his fellow citizens and is content with whatever the state assigns to him.

7 The parts of the whole—everything, I mean, that is naturally contained in the universe—must necessarily perish; but understand this in the sense that they must undergo change. Now if change were by nature both an evil and a necessity for the parts, the whole could not continue in good condition, with its parts subject to change and so constituted as to perish in various ways. For did Nature herself deliberately set out to do evil to her own parts, making them subject to evil and bound to fall into it of necessity—or did such results come about without her knowing? Both suppositions are unbelievable. But suppose someone drops the term Nature as an active power and merely calls

these things natural: even then it would be absurd to say that the parts of the whole are by nature subject to change, and at the same time to be surprised or annoyed as though something were happening contrary to nature—especially since each thing dissolves into the very elements of which it is composed. For there is either a scattering of the elements out of which everything was compounded, or a change from the solid into the earthy and from the airy into the aerial, so that these parts are taken back into the universal reason—whether the universe is consumed by fire at fixed periods or renewed by eternal changes. And do not imagine that the solid and the airy parts of you have belonged to you since birth. All of it took on its growth only yesterday and the day before, so to speak, from the food you eat and the air you breathe. So it is this—what has grown—that changes, not what your mother brought forth. But suppose what your mother brought forth is closely bound up with that other part, the one that has the peculiar quality of changing: that is no objection at all to what I have said.

8 Once you have taken on these names—good, modest, truthful, rational, even-tempered, high-minded—take care never to exchange them for others; and if you ever lose them, return to them quickly. Remember that ‘rational’ was meant to signify a discriminating attention to each particular thing and a freedom from carelessness; that ‘even-tempered’ means the willing acceptance of whatever the common nature assigns to you; and that ‘high-minded’ means the elevation of the thinking part above the pleasant or painful sensations of the flesh, above that poor thing called fame, and above death and all such things. If, then, you keep hold of these names without craving to be called

by them by others, you will be a different person and will enter a different life. For to go on being what you have been until now—torn to pieces and defiled in such a life—is the mark of a very stupid man, far too fond of his life, like those half-devoured fighters in the arena who, though covered in wounds and gore, still beg to be kept until the next day, when they will be thrown out in the same state to the same claws and teeth. So plant yourself firmly in these few names, and if you are able to abide in them, abide as if you had been carried off to the Islands of the Blessed. But if you find that you are falling away from them and cannot keep your hold, then go bravely off into some corner where you can keep them—or even depart from life altogether, not in passion, but with simplicity and freedom and modesty, having at least done this one praiseworthy thing in your life, to have left it in this way. To help you remember these names, it will greatly help to remember the gods, and that they do not wish to be flattered but wish all reasonable beings to become like themselves; and to remember that what does the work of a fig tree is a fig tree, what does the work of a dog is a dog, what does the work of a bee is a bee, and what does the work of a man is a man.

9 “For there, indeed, man’s life is easiest: no snow, no raging storm, no rain is there, but always Ocean sends up the gently breathing breezes of the West Wind to refresh mankind.”

10 War, amazement, sluggishness, slavery, and the mime-shows of life will day by day wipe out those holy principles of yours—principles you picture without studying nature, and just as many that you neglect. Yet it is your duty to look at and to do everything in such a way that, at one

and the same time, your power to deal with circumstances is brought to perfection, your contemplative faculty is exercised, and the confidence that comes from knowing each particular thing is kept—not displayed, but not concealed either. For when will you ever enjoy simplicity, when gravity, when the knowledge of each particular thing—what it is in substance, what place it holds in the universe, how long it is formed to last, what it is made of, to whom it can belong, and who can both give it and take it away?

11 A spider is proud when it catches a fly, one man when he catches a hare, another when he nets a little fish, another when he takes wild boars, another bears, and another Sarmatians. If you examine their principles, are these last not robbers too?

12 Acquire the contemplative way of seeing how all things change into one another; attend to it constantly and train yourself in this part of philosophy. Nothing is so apt to produce greatness of mind. Such a man has set aside the body, and seeing that he must—no one knows how soon—depart from among men and leave everything behind, he gives himself up entirely to acting justly in all that he does and to resigning himself, in everything else that happens, to the universal nature. As for what anyone may say or think about him or do against him, he never even gives it a thought, being content with these two things: to act justly in what he is now doing, and to be satisfied with what is now assigned to him. He lays aside all distracting and busy pursuits, and desires nothing else than to run the straight course according to the law, and by running the straight course to follow God.

13 What need is there for anxious suspicion, when it is in your power to inquire what ought to be done? If you see clearly, then go this way contentedly, without turning back; if you do not see clearly, then stop and take the best advice. But if other things stand in your way, go on as your powers allow, with careful consideration, holding to what seems just. For it is best to reach that goal, and if you fail, let your failure be in the attempt to reach it. The man who follows reason in all things is at once tranquil and active, cheerful and composed.

14 As soon as you wake from sleep, ask yourself whether it will make any difference to you if another person does what is just and right. It will make no difference.

15 You have not forgotten, I trust, that those who put on arrogant airs in dealing out their praise or blame to others are just what they are at bed and at table; you have not forgotten what they do, what they avoid, what they pursue, and how they steal and rob—not with hands and feet, but with their most valuable part, the part by which a man, when he chooses, produces fidelity, modesty, truth, law, and a good guiding spirit.

16 To Nature, who gives all things and takes them back, the man who is well taught and modest says: Give what you will; take back what you will. And he says this not out of pride, but in obedience, and well pleased with her.

17 Short is the little that remains of your life. Live as on a mountain. For it makes no difference whether a man lives here or there, if he lives everywhere in the world as in a city. Let people see, let them know, a real man who lives according to nature. If they cannot endure him, let them kill him—for that is better than to live as men do.

18 No longer talk at all about the kind of man a good man ought to be. Be one.

19 Constantly contemplate the whole of time and the whole of substance, and consider that, in substance, every individual thing is but a grain of a fig, and in time but the single turn of a drill.

20 Look at everything that exists and observe that it is already breaking up and changing—a kind of decay or scattering—and that everything is so constituted by nature as to die.

21 Consider what men are when they are eating, sleeping, mating, relieving themselves, and so on. Then consider what kind of men they are when they are domineering and arrogant, or angry and scolding from their lofty positions. Yet a little while ago, to how many were they slaves, and for what things—and after a little while, consider the condition they will be in.

22 What the universal nature brings to each thing is for the good of that thing—and it is for its good at the very time nature brings it.

23 “The earth loves the rain,” and “the majestic sky loves”—and the universe loves to bring about whatever is about to be. So I say to the universe: I love along with you. And is this not also why we say that this or that ‘loves’—is wont—to come about?

24 Either you go on living here and have grown accustomed to it; or you are going away, and that was your own wish; or you are dying and have discharged your duty. Beyond these there is nothing. So take heart.

25 Always keep it clear to yourself that this patch of land is like any other, and that everything here is the same as on a mountaintop, or by the seashore, or wherever you choose to be. For you will find exactly what Plato says: dwelling within the walls of a city as in a shepherd's fold on a mountain.

26 What is my ruling faculty to me right now? What sort of thing am I now making it? For what purpose am I now using it? Is it empty of understanding? Is it cut loose and torn away from social life? Is it melted and mixed into this poor flesh, so that it moves along with it?

27 He who runs away from his master is a runaway slave. The law is our master, and whoever breaks the law is a runaway. So too is the man who is grieved or angry or afraid, because he is dissatisfied that something has been, is, or will be among the things appointed by the one who rules all things—and that ruler is Law, who assigns each man his due. The man, then, who fears or grieves or rages is a runaway.

28 A man deposits seed in a womb and goes away, and then another cause takes it up, works on it, and makes a child. What a thing from such material! Again, the child sends food down through its throat, and then another cause takes it and makes perception and movement, and in the end life and strength and all the rest—so many things, and so strange! Observe, then, the things produced in this hidden way, and see the power behind them, just as we see the power that carries things downward and upward—not with our eyes, yet no less plainly.

29 Constantly consider that all things, just as they are now, also were in time past, and that they will be the same again. Set before your eyes whole dramas and scenes of the same

pattern, whatever you have learned from your own experience or from older history—for example, the whole court of Hadrian, the whole court of Antoninus, the whole court of Philip, Alexander, Croesus. All of those were just such dramas as we see now, only with different actors.

30 Imagine every man who is grieved or discontented at anything to be like a pig being sacrificed, kicking and squealing.

31 Like this pig, too, is the man who, lying on his bed in silence, laments the bonds in which we are held. And consider that to the rational creature alone is it given to follow willingly what happens; merely to follow is a necessity imposed on all.

32 On the occasion of each thing you do, pause and ask yourself whether death is a dreadful thing because it deprives you of this.

33 When you are offended at another man's fault, turn at once to yourself and reflect how you commit the same sort of error—for example, in thinking that money is a good thing, or pleasure, or a bit of reputation, and the like. By attending to this, you will quickly forget your anger, especially if you also consider that the man is under compulsion—for what else could he do? Or, if you are able, remove the compulsion from him.

34 When you have seen Satyron the Socratic, think of Eutyches or Hymen; when you have seen Euphrates, think of Eutychion or Silvanus; when you have seen Alciphron, think of Tropaeophorus; when you have seen Xenophon, think of Crito or Severus; and when you have looked at yourself, think of one of the other Caesars—and in every case do the same. Then let this thought come to mind: Where, then,

are those men now? Nowhere, or nobody knows where. For in this way you will continually see human things as smoke and nothing at all, especially if you also reflect that what has once changed will never exist again in all the infinite span of time. And you—in how brief a stretch of time is your own existence? Why, then, are you not content to pass through this short time in an orderly way? What material and opportunity for your activity are you turning away from? For what else are all these things but exercises for the reason, once it has examined carefully and by close inquiry into their nature the things that happen in life? Persevere, then, until you have made these things your own—as a strengthened stomach makes all things its own, as a blazing fire turns whatever is thrown into it into flame and brightness.

35 Let it never be in any man's power to say truly of you that you are not simple or that you are not good; let whoever thinks anything of the kind about you be a liar. And this is entirely in your power. For who is there to stop you from being good and simple? Only resolve to live no longer if you cannot be such—for reason itself does not allow you to live if you are not.

36 In dealing with the material of our life, what can be done or said in the way most in keeping with reason? Whatever it may be, it is in your power to do it or to say it; so do not make excuses that you are hindered. You will not stop your lamenting until your mind reaches a state where doing the things in keeping with man's constitution, in whatever matter is set before you, is to you what luxury is to those who pursue pleasure. For a man ought to consider as an enjoyment everything it is in his power to do according

to his own nature—and that is in his power everywhere. Now a cylinder is not given the power to move everywhere by its own motion, nor is water, nor fire, nor anything else governed by nature or by an irrational soul, for the things that check them and stand in their way are many. But intelligence and reason are able to make their way through everything that opposes them, in the manner they are formed by nature and as they choose. Set before your eyes this ease with which reason will be carried through all things, as fire moves upward, a stone downward, a cylinder down a slope—and seek nothing further. For all other obstacles either affect only the body, which is a dead thing, or—except through opinion and the yielding of reason itself—they do not crush us or do any harm at all; for if they did, the one who felt it would at once become bad. Indeed, in everything that has a certain constitution, whatever harm befalls it makes the thing that suffers it correspondingly worse; but in a man's case, he becomes better, if one may say so, and more worthy of praise by making right use of such accidents. And in the end, remember that nothing harms the man who is truly a citizen unless it harms the state, and nothing harms the state unless it harms law and order; and of the things called misfortunes, not one harms law. What, then, does not harm law harms neither state nor citizen.

37 To the man steeped in true principles, even the briefest reminder is enough, any common precept, to recall him to a life free from grief and fear. For example:

38 “Leaves—some the wind scatters on the ground—so is the race of men.”

39 Leaves, too, are your children; leaves are those who cry out as if they deserved to be believed and bestow their praise, or on the contrary curse, or secretly blame and sneer; and leaves likewise are those who will receive and hand down a man's fame to later ages. For all such things "are produced in the season of spring," as the poet says; then the wind casts them down; then the forest brings forth other leaves in their place. A brief existence is common to all things, and yet you avoid and pursue them all as though they would last forever. In a little while you will close your eyes, and the man who carried you to your grave will soon be mourned by another.

40 A healthy eye ought to look at everything visible and not say, 'I want only green things'—for that is the condition of a diseased eye. Healthy hearing and smell ought to be ready to perceive all that can be heard and smelled. A healthy stomach ought to be toward all food just as a mill is toward all that it is made to grind. And so a healthy understanding ought to be ready for everything that happens; but the understanding that says, 'Let my dear children live, and let all men praise whatever I do,' is an eye that wants only green things, or teeth that want only soft food.

41 There is no man so fortunate that, when he is dying, there will not be some standing by who are pleased at what is about to happen. Suppose he was a good and wise man: will there not be at least someone to say to himself, 'Let us at last breathe freely, now that we are relieved of this schoolmaster? True, he was harsh to none of us, but I sensed that he silently condemned us'? That is what is said of a good man. But in our own case, how many other reasons are there why so many wish to be rid of us? Consider

this, then, when you are dying, and you will depart more contentedly by reflecting thus: I am leaving a life in which even my own companions—those for whom I strove so much, prayed, and cared—theirselfs wish me gone, hoping perhaps to gain some small advantage by it. Why, then, should a man cling to a longer stay here? Yet do not on that account leave them any less kindly disposed; keep your own character, friendly and benevolent and gentle, and do not depart as if you were being torn away. Rather, just as when a man dies a quiet death the poor soul is easily separated from the body, so too should your departure from men be. For nature bound you to them and joined you with them—and now she dissolves the union. I am separated as from kinsmen, yet not dragged off resisting, but going without compulsion; for this too is one of the things in keeping with nature.

42 Train yourself, as much as you can, whenever anyone does anything, to ask yourself: For what purpose is this man doing this? But begin with yourself, and examine yourself first.

43 Remember that what pulls the strings is the thing hidden within: this is the power of persuasion, this is life, this, one might say, is the man. In picturing yourself, never include the vessel that surrounds you and these instruments attached to it. For they are like an axe, differing only in that they have grown onto the body. Indeed, these parts are of no more use without the cause that moves and checks them than a weaver's shuttle is without the weaver, a pen without the writer, or a whip without the driver.

B O O K

XI

Explores the rational soul's unique powers, its kinship with others, and how to handle those who offend us with understanding rather than anger. The book closes with a set of borrowed maxims, several from Epictetus.

1 These are the properties of the rational soul: it sees itself, analyzes itself, and makes itself whatever it chooses. The fruit it bears, it enjoys itself—whereas the fruit of plants, and what corresponds to fruit in animals, others enjoy. It reaches its own end wherever the limit of life happens to fall. It is not like a dance or a play or anything of that kind, where the whole performance is left incomplete if something cuts it short; rather, in every part, and wherever it may be stopped, it makes whatever was set before it full and complete, so that it can say, “I have what is my own.” What is more, it ranges over the whole universe and the empty space surrounding it, surveys its shape, reaches out into the infinity of time, and embraces and grasps the periodic renewal of all things. It understands that those who come after us will see nothing new, and that those before

us saw nothing more; in a sense, anyone forty years old who has any understanding at all has already seen, through the uniformity that prevails, everything that has been and everything that will be. This too is a property of the rational soul: love of your neighbor, and truth, and modesty, and valuing nothing more than itself—which is also a property of Law. So right reason and the reason of justice are no different at all.

2 You will set little value on a pleasing song, or on dancing, or on the wrestling match, if you break the melody of the voice down into its separate sounds and ask yourself, about each one, whether this is what has mastered you—for shame will keep you from admitting it. Do the same with dancing, taking each movement and posture separately, and the same with the wrestling match. In all things, then—except virtue and the acts of virtue—remember to break them down into their parts, and by this dividing learn to value them little. Apply this rule to your whole life as well.

3 What a soul it is that is ready, the moment it must be separated from the body, to be extinguished, or scattered, or to go on existing—but ready in a way that comes from its own considered judgment, not from sheer stubbornness, as with the Christians, but with deliberation and dignity, and in a way that could persuade another, without any theatrical display.

4 Have I done something for the common good? Then I have had my reward. Keep this always before your mind, and never stop doing such good.

5 What is your craft? To be good. And how is that done well, except through general principles—some about the

nature of the universe, others about the proper makeup of a human being?

6 Tragedies were first brought onto the stage to remind people of the things that happen to them, and that it is according to nature for such things to happen, and that if you enjoy watching them on the stage you should not be distressed when they take place on the larger stage of life. For you see that these things must turn out this way, and that even those who cry out “O Cithaeron!” still have to bear them. And indeed the dramatists do say some things well, especially lines like this one: “If the gods neglect me and my children, this too has its reason.” And again: “We must not chafe and fret at what happens.” And: “Reap life’s harvest like a ripe ear of wheat.” And other things of the same kind. After tragedy came the old comedy, with its blunt freedom of speech, useful by its very plainness in reminding people to beware of arrogance—which is also why Diogenes drew on these writers. As for the middle comedy that came next, look at what it was; and consider, too, what the new comedy was introduced for, which gradually sank into mere mimicry and stage trickery. Everyone knows that even these writers say some good things—but the whole aim of such poetry and drama, what does it ultimately come to?

7 How plainly it appears that there is no condition of life so well suited to philosophy as this one you happen to be in right now.

8 A branch cut off from the branch next to it is necessarily cut off from the whole tree as well. In the same way, a person cut off from another person has fallen away from the whole community. Now a branch is cut off by someone else, but a person cuts himself off from his neighbor by his

own act, when he hates him and turns away from him—not realizing that at the same time he has cut himself off from the whole social system. Yet he still has this gift from Zeus, who framed society: it is in our power to grow back onto what is near us and to become once more a part that helps make up the whole. But if this kind of separation happens often, it becomes hard for the part that detaches itself to be brought back into unity and restored to its former state. In the end, the branch that grew with the tree from the start and shared one life with it is not the same as one that is cut off and then grafted back on. As the gardeners put it, such a branch grows together with the rest of the tree, but it does not share the same mind with it.

9 Just as those who try to block your way when you are acting according to right reason cannot turn you aside from your proper course, do not let them drive you from your goodwill toward them either. Stand guard equally on both fronts: not only in steadiness of judgment and action, but also in gentleness toward those who try to hinder you or otherwise give you trouble. For it is a weakness to be irritated at them, just as it is a weakness to be turned from your action or to give way through fear. Both are deserters from their post—the one who acts from fear, and the one who becomes estranged from a man who is by nature his kinsman and friend.

10 No nature is inferior to art, for the arts imitate the natures of things. And if that is so, then the most perfect and all-embracing of natures cannot fall short of the skill of art. Now all the arts make lesser things for the sake of greater ones; so the universal nature does the same. And from this, in fact, comes the origin of justice, and on justice the other

virtues are founded—for justice will not be honored if we care about indifferent things, or if we are easily deceived, careless, and changeable.

11 If the things whose pursuit and avoidance disturb you do not come to you, still, in a way, you go to them. Let your judgment about them be at rest, then, and they will stay quiet, and you will not be seen either chasing or fleeing anything.

12 The soul keeps its spherical form when it is neither stretched out toward any object, nor drawn inward, nor scattered, nor collapsed inward, but is lit by a light through which it sees the truth—the truth of all things and the truth that is in itself.

13 Suppose someone despises me. That is his concern. Mine is to make sure I am not caught doing or saying anything that deserves contempt. Suppose someone hates me. That too is his concern. I will be mild and kindly toward everyone, ready even to show that man his mistake—not in reproach, nor as a show of my own patience, but honestly and nobly, like the great Phocion (unless even he was only pretending). For the inner self ought to be like this, and a man ought to be seen by the gods neither dissatisfied with anything nor complaining. What harm can it be to you, if you are now doing what suits your own nature and are content with what at this moment suits the nature of the universe—you, a human being stationed at your post so that the common good may somehow be served?

14 People look down on one another and flatter one another; they want to rise above one another, and yet they grovel before one another.

15 How false and insincere is the man who says, “I have made up my mind to deal honestly with you!” What are you doing, man? There is no need to announce it. It will show itself soon enough in your actions. The truth ought to be plainly written on your forehead. A person’s character shows at once in his eyes, just as someone who is loved reads everything in the eyes of those who love him. A man who is honest and good ought to be like a man with a strong smell, so that anyone who comes near him cannot help noticing it whether he wants to or not. But a put-on simplicity is like a crooked stick. Nothing is more disgraceful than a wolfish, false friendship. Avoid that above all. The good, simple, kindly man shows all this in his eyes; there is no mistaking it.

16 As for living in the best way, this power lies in the soul, provided it stays indifferent to things that are indifferent. And it will stay indifferent if it looks at each of these things separately and all together, and remembers that none of them forces an opinion of itself on us or comes to us; they stay still and unmoving, and it is we ourselves who form the judgments about them and, so to speak, write them into ourselves—when it is in our power not to write them, and in our power, if such judgments have slipped in unnoticed, to wipe them out. Remember too that such attention is needed only for a short while, and then life will be over. Besides, what is so hard about doing this? If these things are according to nature, take joy in them and they will come easily; but if they are contrary to nature, look for what agrees with your own nature and strive toward that, even if it brings no reputation—for every man is allowed to seek his own good.

17 Consider where each thing comes from, what it is made of, what it changes into, and what kind of thing it will be once it has changed—and that it will take no harm at all.

18 If anyone has wronged you, consider this first: what is my relation to other people? We are made for one another; and, in another sense, I was made to be set over them, as a ram over the flock or a bull over the herd. But examine the matter from first principles, this way: if all things are not mere atoms, then it is nature that orders everything; and if that is so, the lesser things exist for the sake of the greater, and these for the sake of one another.

19 Second, consider what kind of men they are at the table, in bed, and so on; and especially what compulsions of opinion they are under; and as for their acts, with what pride they do what they do.

20 Third, that if people do rightly what they do, we have no reason to be displeased; and if they do wrong, it is plainly against their will and out of ignorance. For just as every soul is robbed of the truth against its will, so too it is robbed against its will of the power to treat each person as he deserves. That is why people are stung when they are called unjust, ungrateful, greedy—in a word, wrongdoers toward their neighbors.

21 Fourth, consider that you too do many things wrong, and that you are a man like the rest. And even if you do hold back from certain faults, you still have the disposition to commit them, and if you refrain it is only through cowardice, or concern for your reputation, or some such mean motive.

22 Fifth, consider that you do not even really know whether people are doing wrong or not, for many things are done with some reference to circumstances. In short, a man must

learn a great deal before he can judge another man's actions correctly.

23 Sixth, consider, when you are very vexed or grieved, that a man's life is only a moment, and that in a short time we are all laid out dead.

24 Seventh, that it is not people's acts that disturb us, for those acts rest on their own ruling principles; it is our own opinions that disturb us. Take away these opinions, then—resolve to drop your judgment that the act is something dreadful—and your anger is gone. And how do I take away these opinions? By reflecting that no wrong done by another brings shame on me. For unless what is shameful were the only bad thing, I too would necessarily do many wrongs and become a robber and everything else.

25 Eighth, consider how much more pain is caused us by the anger and vexation over such acts than by the acts themselves that we are angry and vexed about.

26 Ninth, consider that a good disposition is unconquerable, provided it is genuine and not an affected smile and play-acting. For what can even the most violent man do to you if you go on being kind toward him, and, as the chance arises, gently advise him and calmly correct his errors at the very moment he is trying to harm you—saying, “Not so, my child; we were made by nature for something else. You will certainly not injure me, but you are injuring yourself, my child.” And show him, with gentle tact and by general principles, that this is so—that not even bees behave as he does, nor any animals that nature has made to live in groups. And you must do this without any double meaning and without reproach, but affectionately and with no bitterness in your soul—not as if you were lecturing him, nor so that any

bystander might admire you, but either when he is alone, or, if others are present, gently take him aside.

27 Remember these nine rules as if you had received them as a gift from the Muses, and begin at last to be a man while you are alive. But you must equally avoid flattering people and being vexed at them, for both are unsocial and lead to harm. And keep this truth before you when anger flares up: that to be moved by passion is not manly, whereas mildness and gentleness, as they are more in keeping with human nature, are also more manly. The man who has these qualities has strength, sinew, and courage—not the man given to fits of passion and discontent. For the nearer a man's mind comes to freedom from passion, the nearer it comes to strength; and just as pain is a mark of weakness, so is anger. The man who gives way to pain and the man who gives way to anger are both wounded, and both have surrendered.

28 And if you will, take a tenth gift as well, from the leader of the Muses, Apollo: that to expect bad men not to do wrong is madness, for that is to want the impossible. But to allow them to behave so toward others while expecting them not to wrong you is irrational and tyrannical.

29 There are four chief errors of the ruling faculty to be constantly on guard against; when you have caught them, wipe them out, saying in each case: "This thought is not necessary." "This one tends to destroy the bonds of society." "What you are about to say does not come from your real thoughts"—and you should count it among the most absurd of things for a man not to speak from his real thoughts. And the fourth is when you reproach yourself, for that is proof that the diviner part within you has been

overpowered and is yielding to the lower, perishable part—the body—and to its coarse pleasures.

30 The airy part in you and all the fiery parts mixed into you, though by nature they tend upward, still obey the arrangement of the universe and are held down here in the compound mass of the body. And the earthy and watery parts in you, though their tendency is downward, are still raised up and kept in a position that is not their natural one. In this way the elements obey the whole: once fixed in some place, they stay there by necessity until the universe again sounds the signal for their dissolution. Is it not strange, then, that only your intelligent part should be disobedient and discontented with its place? And yet nothing is forced on it but what agrees with its own nature; still it does not submit, but is carried the opposite way. For the movement toward injustice, intemperance, anger, grief, and fear is nothing but the act of one who departs from nature. And when the ruling faculty is discontented with anything that happens, it too is deserting its post, for it was made for piety and reverence toward the gods no less than for justice. These qualities, too, are included under the general heading of contentment with the way things are constituted—indeed, they come before acts of justice.

31 A man who does not have one and the same aim throughout his life cannot be one and the same person throughout his life. But what I have said is not enough unless this is added too: what that aim ought to be. For just as people do not hold the same view about all the things commonly thought to be good, but only about certain ones—those that concern the common interest—so too the aim we set before ourselves should be of a common, social, and

civic kind. The man who directs all his efforts toward this aim will make all his actions of one piece, and so he will always be the same.

32 Think of the country mouse and the town mouse, and of the alarm and panic of the town mouse.

33 Socrates used to call the opinions of the crowd “Lamiae”—bogeymen to frighten children.

34 At their public spectacles the Spartans used to set out seats in the shade for strangers, while they themselves sat down wherever they could.

35 Socrates made his excuses to Perdiccas for not visiting him, saying it was because he did not want to perish by the worst of all deaths—that is, to receive a favor and then be unable to return it.

36 In the writings of the Ephesians there was this precept: to keep thinking of someone from earlier times who practiced virtue.

37 The Pythagoreans tell us to look up at the heavens in the morning, so that we may be reminded of those bodies that forever do the same things in the same way as they go about their work, and reminded too of their purity and their nakedness—for there is no veil over a star.

38 Consider what a man Socrates was, when he wrapped himself in a skin after Xanthippe had taken his cloak and gone out, and what he said to the friends who were ashamed of him and shrank back when they saw him dressed like that.

39 Neither in writing nor in reading will you be able to set down rules for others before you have first learned to obey rules yourself. And this is far more true in life.

40 You are a slave: free speech is not for you.

41 “And my heart laughed within me.”

42 “And they will curse virtue, speaking harsh words.”

43 To look for a fig in winter is a madman’s act; and so is the man who looks for his child when it is no longer permitted.

44 When a man kisses his child, said Epictetus, he should whisper to himself, “Perhaps tomorrow you will die.” But those are words of bad omen. “No word is of bad omen,” said Epictetus, “that names a work of nature; or, if it is, then it is also of bad omen to speak of the ears of corn being reaped.”

45 The unripe grape, the ripe cluster, the dried raisin—all are changes, not into nothing, but into something that does not yet exist.

46 No one can rob us of our free will.

47 Epictetus also said that a man must work out an art, or set of rules, for giving his assent; and in his impulses to act he must take care that they suit the circumstances, serve the common interest, and match the worth of their object; and as for sensual desire, he should keep away from it altogether; and as for aversion, he should not direct it at anything that is not in our power.

48 The dispute, then, he said, is not about some trivial matter, but about whether we are sane or mad.

49 Socrates used to ask: What do you want—the souls of rational beings, or of irrational ones? Of rational ones. Of what kind of rational beings—sound or unsound? Sound. Then why do you not look for them? Because we already have them. Then why do you fight and quarrel?

B O O K

XII

*A gathering of final reflections on living each moment with
piety and justice and meeting death without fear. It ends
with the image of life as a play: leave the stage content
when nature, the one who cast you, calls you off.*

1 Everything you hope to reach by some roundabout path, you can have right now, if you stop denying it to yourself. And this means: take no notice of all the past, trust the future to providence, and direct only the present in line with piety and justice. In line with piety, so that you are content with the lot assigned to you, for nature designed it for you and you for it. In line with justice, so that you always speak the truth freely and without disguise, and do what accords with the law and with the worth of each person. Don't let yourself be held back by another's wickedness, nor by opinion, nor by anyone's words, nor even by the sensations of the poor flesh that has grown around you, for that passive part can look after itself. If then, whenever the time comes that you are near your departure, you set everything else aside and respect only your ruling faculty and the

divinity within you, and if you are afraid not because you must someday stop living, but rather that you may never have begun to live according to nature, then you will be a person worthy of the universe that produced you. You will no longer be a stranger in your own homeland, no longer astonished at things that happen daily as if they were unexpected, and no longer dependent on this or that.

2 God sees the minds of all people stripped bare of their material clothing, their husk, their impurities. For with his intellectual part alone he touches only the intelligence that has flowed and been derived from himself into these bodies. And if you train yourself to do the same, you will rid yourself of much trouble. For someone who pays no attention to the poor flesh that wraps him will surely not bother himself chasing after clothing, housing, fame, and other such externals and show.

3 There are three things you are made of: a little body, a little breath, and intelligence. The first two are yours only in the sense that it is your duty to take care of them, but the third alone is truly yours. So if you separate from yourself, that is, from your understanding, whatever others do or say, and whatever you yourself have done or said, and whatever future things trouble you because they might happen, and whatever in the body that wraps you or in the breath naturally joined to it is attached to you independent of your will, and whatever the external swirling current whirls around you, so that your intellectual power, exempt from the things of fate, can live pure and free by itself, doing what is just, accepting what happens, and speaking the truth; if you separate, I say, from this ruling faculty the things that cling to it through the impressions of the senses, and the

things of time to come and time past, and make yourself like Empedocles' sphere, "all round, and resting in its own joyous repose"; and if you strive to live only what is really your life, that is, the present, then you will be able to spend whatever portion of life remains to you, right up to your death, free from disturbance, nobly, and obedient to the god that is within you.

4 I have often wondered how it is that every person loves himself more than everyone else, yet sets less value on his own opinion of himself than on the opinions of others. If a god or a wise teacher were to appear and order a man to think nothing and plan nothing that he would not say aloud the moment he conceived it, he could not bear it even for a single day. So much more do we respect what our neighbors will think of us than what we think of ourselves.

5 How can it be that the gods, having arranged everything well and kindly for humankind, overlooked this one thing: that some people, and very good ones, people who have had the closest communion with the divine and through pious acts and religious observance have been most intimate with it, once they have died should never exist again but be completely snuffed out? But if this is so, rest assured that it ought to have been otherwise, the gods would have made it so. For if it were just, it would also be possible; and if it were according to nature, nature would have arranged it that way. But because it is not so, if in fact it is not so, then be convinced that it ought not to have been so. For you can see for yourself that in raising this question you are arguing with the Deity, and we would not argue with the gods this way unless they were utterly excellent and just; and if they

are, they would not have allowed anything in the ordering of the universe to be unjustly or irrationally neglected.

6 Practice yourself even in the things you despair of accomplishing. For even the left hand, useless at everything else for lack of practice, grips the bridle more firmly than the right, because it has been practiced at this.

7 Consider what condition a person should be in, in both body and soul, when death overtakes him; and consider the shortness of life, the boundless abyss of time past and to come, and the feebleness of all matter.

8 Contemplate the formative principles of things stripped of their coverings; the purposes behind actions; consider what pain is, what pleasure is, and death, and fame; consider that each person is the cause of his own unease, that no one is hindered by another, and that everything is a matter of opinion.

9 In applying your principles, be like the all-in fighter, not the swordsman; for the swordsman drops the sword he uses and is killed, but the fighter always has his hand and need do nothing but use it.

10 See things as they are in themselves, dividing them into matter, form, and purpose.

11 What power a person has to do nothing except what God will approve, and to accept everything God may give him.

12 As for what happens according to nature, we should blame neither the gods, since they do nothing wrong either willingly or unwillingly, nor other people, since they do nothing wrong except unwillingly. So we should blame no one.

13 How ridiculous, and what a stranger to life, is the person who is surprised at anything that happens in it.

14 Either there is a fated necessity and an unbreakable order, or a kind providence, or a confusion without purpose and without anyone directing it. If there is an unbreakable necessity, why do you resist? But if there is a providence that allows itself to be won over, make yourself worthy of the divinity's help. And if there is a confusion with no one governing it, be content that in such a storm you have within yourself a certain ruling intelligence. And even if the storm sweeps you away, let it sweep away the poor flesh, the poor breath, and everything else; for the intelligence, at least, it will not sweep away.

15 Does the light of the lamp shine without losing its brightness until it is put out? And shall the truth, the justice, and the self-control within you be put out before your death?

16 When someone appears to have done wrong, ask: how do I really know this was a wrongful act? And even if he did wrong, how do I know he has not already condemned himself, so that this is like clawing his own face? Consider that wanting a bad man not to do wrong is like wanting the fig tree not to yield juice in its figs, or babies not to cry, or the horse not to neigh, or anything else that must happen of necessity. For what else can a man do who has such a character? If this irritates you, then cure his disposition.

17 If it is not right, do not do it; if it is not true, do not say it.

18 In everything, always observe what the thing is that produces an impression on you, and break it down by dividing it into its form, its matter, its purpose, and the span of time within which it must end.

19 Realize at last that you have within you something better and more divine than the things that stir your passions and pull you about like a puppet on strings. What is in my mind right now? Is it fear, suspicion, desire, or something of the kind?

20 First, do nothing aimlessly or without a purpose. Second, let your actions aim at nothing but the good of the community.

21 Consider that before long you will be no one and nowhere, and none of the things you now see will exist, nor any of the people now living. For all things are made by nature to change, to be transformed, and to perish, so that other things may come into being in continuous succession.

22 Consider that everything is opinion, and opinion is in your power. So take away your opinion whenever you choose, and like a sailor who has rounded the headland, you will find calm, everything steady, a waveless bay.

23 Any activity, whatever it is, when it ends at its proper time suffers no harm by ending; nor does the one who performed it suffer any harm for the reason that the act has ended. In the same way, the whole made up of all our acts, which is our life, if it ends at its proper time suffers no harm by ending; nor is the one who brings this series to a close at the proper time badly treated. The proper time and the limit are fixed by nature, sometimes by a person's own nature, as in old age, but always by the universal nature, by the changing of whose parts the whole universe stays ever young and perfect. And whatever is useful to the whole is always good and timely. So the end of life is no evil for anyone, since it is not shameful, being beyond our will and

not opposed to the common good; rather it is good, since it is timely and useful and fitting to the whole. For in this way too a person is moved by the Deity, when he is moved as the Deity is moved, and moved in his mind toward the same end.

24 Keep these three principles ready. First, in what you do, do nothing aimlessly or otherwise than justice herself would act; and as for what may come to you from outside, consider that it happens either by chance or by providence, and you must neither blame chance nor accuse providence. Second, consider what each being is from its seed until it receives a soul, and from receiving a soul until it gives that soul back, and what each is composed of and into what it dissolves. Third, that if you were suddenly lifted high above the earth and looked down on human affairs and saw how varied they are, and at the same time saw at a glance the great number of beings who dwell all around in the air and the heavens, you would see, however often you were lifted up, the very same things: the same forms, the same brief duration. Are these things to be proud of?

25 Throw away opinion, and you are saved. Who, then, stops you from throwing it away?

26 When you are troubled about anything, you have forgotten this: that all things happen according to the universal nature. And you have forgotten that another person's wrongful act is nothing to you. And you have forgotten that everything that happens always happened this way, will happen this way, and is happening this way everywhere right now. And you have forgotten how close the kinship is between one person and the whole human race, for it is a community not of a little blood or seed but of intelligence.

And you have forgotten that each person's intelligence is a god and an outflow of the Deity; and that nothing is truly a person's own, but that his child, his body, and his very soul came from the Deity; and that everything is opinion; and, lastly, that every person lives only the present moment, and loses only this.

27 Constantly call to mind those who have complained loudly about something, those who were most conspicuous for the greatest fame, misfortunes, feuds, or fortunes of any kind, and then ask: where are they all now? Smoke and ash and a tale, or not even a tale. Bring to mind too every example of this sort: how Fabius Catellinus lived on his country estate, Lucius Lupus in his gardens, Stertinius at Baiae, Tiberius at Capri, and Velius Rufus, and in short the eager pursuit of anything joined with pride, and how worthless everything is that people violently strain after, and how much more philosophical it is for a person, in the opportunities given to him, to show himself just, self-controlled, and obedient to the gods, and to do this in all simplicity; for the pride that prides itself on having no pride is the most unbearable pride of all.

28 To those who ask, Where have you seen the gods, or how do you grasp that they exist, that you worship them? I answer, first, that they can be seen even with the eyes; and second, that I have never seen even my own soul, and yet I honor it. So with the gods too: from what I constantly experience of their power, I grasp that they exist, and I revere them.

29 The safety of life lies in this: to examine everything thoroughly, what it is in itself, what its matter is, what its form; and with all your soul to do justice and to speak the

truth. What is left, except to enjoy life by joining one good thing to another so closely as to leave not even the smallest gap between them?

30 There is one light of the sun, though it is broken up by walls, mountains, and countless other things. There is one common substance, though it is distributed among countless bodies, each with its own qualities. There is one soul, though it is distributed among countless natures and individual forms. There is one intelligent soul, though it seems to be divided. Now of the things just mentioned, the other parts, such as air and matter, are without sensation and have no fellowship with one another, and yet even these the intelligent principle holds together, along with their tendency toward the same center. But intellect in a special way tends toward what is akin to it, joins with it, and its feeling for community is not broken off.

31 What do you wish for? To go on existing? Well then, do you wish to have sensation, movement, growth, and then to stop growing, to use your speech, to think? Which of all these seems to you worth desiring? But if it is easy to set little value on all of them, then turn to what remains, which is to follow reason and God. Yet it is inconsistent with honoring reason and God to be troubled that death will deprive you of those other things.

32 How small a part of boundless, unfathomable time is allotted to each of us, for it is soon swallowed up in eternity. And how small a part of the whole of substance, and how small a part of the universal soul; and on what a tiny clod of the whole earth you creep. Reflecting on all this, consider nothing great except to act as your nature leads you and to endure what the common nature brings.

33 How does your ruling faculty make use of itself? Everything depends on this. Everything else, whether it lies within your will or not, is only lifeless ashes and smoke.

34 This reflection is best suited to move us to scorn death: that even those who think pleasure a good and pain an evil have still despised it.

35 For the person to whom only what comes in due season is good, to whom it makes no difference whether he has done more acts or fewer in accord with right reason, to whom it makes no difference whether he contemplates the world for a longer or a shorter time, for this person death too is not a terrible thing.

36 Man, you have been a citizen in this great city, the world; what does it matter to you whether for five years or three? For what accords with its laws is just for all alike. Where is the hardship, then, if you are sent out of the city not by a tyrant or an unjust judge, but by nature, who brought you into it, just as a director who hired an actor dismisses him from the stage? "But I have not finished the five acts, only three." You are right, but in life three acts are the whole play; for the one who once caused its composition and now causes its dissolution decides what counts as a complete drama, and you are the cause of neither. So depart contented, for the one who releases you is also contented.

A NOTE ON THIS EDITION

The Lectio Edition renders Marcus's notebook in clear, living modern English — the sense and force of the Stoic original without the Victorian stiffness of George Long or the archaism of Méric Casaubon. It is synthesised from the public-domain translations and cross-checked against the Greek, then reviewed for fidelity, aiming to read as Marcus's own plain, urgent voice to himself.

HOW IT WAS MADE

Lectio Edition (SDIT): a plain-modern-English rendering produced by deep research, grounded in the public-domain George Long (1862) and Méric Casaubon (1634) translations and cross-checked against the Greek original, then reviewed for fidelity. This is Lectio's own modern edition, derived from public-domain sources — not a historical translation.

SOURCES CONSULTED

- George Long, translation (1862)
- Méric Casaubon, translation (1634)
- Greek original — Τὰ εἰς ἑαυτὸν (Wikisource)

PROVENANCE

Edition	The Lectio Edition · 2026
Model	claude-opus-4-8
Produced	2026-06-15
Tokens used	≈ 242,930 (estimated)
Base text	George Long, 1862
Reference	book.section

On the numbering. The sections are numbered as they fall in this edition, book by book. They follow the traditional divisions closely, but the Lectio Edition sets some runs of short sayings and quoted fragments as sections of their own, so the counts can part company with the older numbering toward the end of a book. Where you need to cite by the standard reference, check the passage against a historical translation — in the app, the Compare panel puts them side by side.

WHERE THIS EDITION DIFFERS

Places where the Lectio Edition departs from the older translations, and why.

THE TITLE

Τὰ εἰς ἑαυτόν

Older	“Meditations” (traditional editorial title)
Lectio	kept as “Meditations,” read as “To Himself”

Marcus gave the work no title; ‘Meditations’ is a later editor’s label. The Greek means ‘To Himself’ — a private notebook, not a treatise. Lectio keeps the familiar name but reads the text as the self-address it actually is.

THROUGHOUT

τὸ ἡγεμονικόν (to hēgemonikon)

Older	“the ruling faculty,” “the governing part” (Long)
Lectio	“the mind that governs you,” “your directing mind”

Long’s literal ‘ruling faculty’ is accurate but opaque. The hēgemonikon is the Stoic term for the rational command-centre of the self; Lectio renders its function plainly rather than transliterating the philosophy.

E.G. 2.13, 3.3, 5.27

δαίμων (daimōn)

Older “the daemon,” “the divinity within” (Long)

Lectio “the spirit within you,” “your inner guide”

‘Daemon’ misleads a modern reader toward ‘demon.’ For the Stoics it is the divine spark of reason each person carries; Lectio renders the idea, not the loaded word.

THE SAME PASSAGE, FOUR WAYS

Book 5, section 16, in every edition Lectio carries for this work — the modern rendering you have just read, the historical translations, and the original. In the app these sit side by side, aligned line for line; here they are set one after another.

THE LECTIO EDITION

Plain modern English — the sense of the original, made to read with ease today.

Such as are your habitual thoughts, such also will your mind's character be, for the soul is dyed by its thoughts. Dye it, then, with a continuous run of thoughts like these: that wherever a man can live, there he can also live well. But suppose he must live in a palace; well then, he can live well in a palace too. And consider further that whatever a thing has been made for, that is what it has been made for, and that is what it is carried toward; and its end lies in what it is carried toward; and where the end is, there too lie the advantage and the good of each thing. Now the good for a reasoning creature is society, for it has been shown above that we are made for society. Isn't it plain that the inferior exists for the sake of the superior? And living things are superior to lifeless ones, and among living things the superior are those that have reason.

MÉRIC CASAUBON, 1634

The first English Meditations — ornate, archaic, devotional.

XIII. All that I consist of, is either form or matter. No corruption can reduce either of these unto nothing; for neither did I of nothing become a subsistent creature. Every part of mine then will by

mutation be disposed into a certain part of the whole world, and that in time into another part; and so *in infinitum*; by which kind of mutation, I also became what I am, and so did they that begot me, and they before them, and so upwards *in infinitum*. For so we may be allowed to speak, though the age and government of the world, be to some certain periods of time limited, and confined.

THE ORIGINAL

The original Koine Greek — Marcus's private notebook (Τὰ εἰς ἑαυτόν).

Οἷα ἂν πολλάκις φαντασθῆς, τοιαύτη σοι ἔσται ἡ διάνοια· βάπτεται γὰρ ὑπὸ τῶν φαντασιῶν ἡ ψυχὴ. βάπτε οὖν αὐτὴν τῇ συνεχείᾳ τῶν τοιούτων φαντασιῶν· οἷον, ὅτι ὅπου ζῆν ἔστιν, ἐκεῖ καὶ εὖ ζῆν· ἐν αὐτῇ δὲ ζῆν ἔστιν· ἔστιν ἄρα καὶ εὖ ζῆν ἐν αὐτῇ. καὶ πάλιν, ὅτι οὐπερ ἔνεκεν ἕκαστον κατεσκεύασται, <πρὸς τοῦτο κατεσκεύασται> πρὸς ὃ δὲ κατεσκεύασται, πρὸς τοῦτο φέρεται· πρὸς ὃ φέρεται δέ, ἐν τούτῳ τὸ τέλος αὐτοῦ· ὅπου δὲ τὸ τέλος, ἐκεῖ καὶ τὸ συμφέρον καὶ τὸ ἀγαθὸν ἐκάστου· τὸ ἄρα ἀγαθὸν τοῦ λογικοῦ ζῶου κοινωνία. ὅτι γὰρ πρὸς κοινωνίαν γεγόναμεν, πάλαι δέδεικται· ἢ οὐκ ἦν ἐναργὲς ὅτι τὰ χεῖρω τῶν κρείττωνων ἔνεκεν, τὰ δὲ κρείττω ἀλλήλων; κρεῖττω δὲ τῶν μὲν ἀψύχων τὰ ἑμψυχα, τῶν δὲ ἐμψύχων τὰ λογικά.

GEORGE LONG, 1862

The classic Victorian standard — clear, dignified, widely read.

16. Such as are thy habitual thoughts, such also will be the character of thy mind; for the soul is dyed by the thoughts. Dye it then with a continuous series of such thoughts as these: for instance, that where a man can live, there he can also live well. But he must live in a palace; well then, he can also live well in a palace. And again, consider that for whatever purpose each thing has been constituted, for this it has been constituted, and towards this it is carried; and its end is in that towards which it is carried; and where the end is, there also is the advantage and the good of each thing. Now the good for the reasonable animal is society; for that we are made for society has been shown above. Is it not plain that the inferior exists for the sake of the superior? But the things which have life

are superior to those which have not life, and of those which have life the superior...

THE OTHER EDITIONS IN LECTIO

Every work in Lectio carries its modern edition and the public-domain texts behind it. One tap in the reader moves between them; they are listed here as they stand in the library.

GEORGE LONG · 1862

The classic Victorian standard — clear, dignified, widely read.

Translator	George Long (1800–1879)
Rights	US public domain; George Long translation, 1862.
Source	https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/15877

MÉRIC CASAUBON · 1634

The first English Meditations — ornate, archaic, devotional.

Translator	Méric Casaubon (1599–1671)
Rights	US public domain; Casaubon translation first published 1634.
Source	https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/2680

THE ORIGINAL

The original Koine Greek — Marcus's private notebook (Τὰ εἰς ἑαυτόν).

Rights	Ancient Greek source text (c. 170–180 CE); public domain.
Source	https://el.wikisource.org/wiki/Τὰ_εἰς_ἑαυτόν

WHERE THIS BOOK LEADS

The threads *Lectio* draws from this work to others in the library.

PARALLEL *The Bhagavad Gita*

Act rightly and release the outcome — the Gita's karma-yoga and Marcus's Stoicism arrive at nearly the same discipline, worlds apart.

INFLUENCES *The Republic*

Stoicism grows from the Socratic root Plato planted: the examined life, the soul ordered by reason.

PARALLEL *The Analects*

Daily self-correction and the cultivation of character — Marcus's morning reminders echo Confucian self-examination.

CONTRASTS *Confessions*

Two interior books: Marcus steadies the self by reason, Augustine surrenders it to God.

THEMES

stoicism · self-mastery · mortality · duty · the present moment

WHO'S WHO IN BOOK I

Verus · Diognetus · Rusticus · Apollonius · Maximus · Antoninus Pius

C O L O P H O N

Meditations — the Lectio Edition — was set from the Lectio content bundle: 12 books, 517 sections, the same text the reader carries.

The text is New York, Apple's serif, the face the app reads in. Headings and running heads are letterspaced small capitals; the section figures and rubrics are set in a single rubrication red, after the medieval practice the design language is named for. Trim 5.5×8.5 inches.

L E C T I O

San Diego Institute of Technology